

Mindful Teaching and Learning



Developing a Pedagogy of Well-Being

EDITED BY

KAREN RAGOONADEN

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Introduction

Mindful Teaching and Learning: Developing a Pedagogy of Well-Being

Karen Ragoonaden

This volume assembles a community of scholar-practitioners from across disciplines, methodologies, and ideological perspectives, exploring and examining contexts that support mindful teaching, mindful learning, and a sustained pedagogy of well-being. Collectively, these chapters document and analyze the opportunities and challenges within pedagogical sites and discuss how mindfulness can impact educational practice and praxis.

Taking its historical roots in Buddhist traditions of movement in meditation, Kabat-Zinn (1990) developed and evaluated the first structured mindfulness-based program (Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction [MBSR]). Over the last twenty-five years, a growing body of empirical substantiation has emerged supporting the efficacy of MBSR programs in reducing stress and improving physical and mental health outcomes. For example, research on the neurobiology of mindfulness in adults suggests that sustained mindfulness practice can enhance attentional and emotional self-regulation and promote flexibility, pointing toward significant potential benefits for both teachers and students (Baer, 2003; Grossman, et al., 2004; Ludwig & Kabat-Zinn, 2008; Ruff & Mackenzie, 2009; Shapiro & Carlson, 2009).

Bolstered by the positive evidence-based standards emanating from clinical settings, mindfulness-based training has spread into a variety of other fields like psychology, healthcare, and more recently, education. Supported by a robust body of evidence-based empirical results, research has demonstrated that mindfulness training strengthens one's capacity to pay attention, nonjudgmentally, to one's thoughts, feelings, and body sensations, thereby

enabling a more skillful response to life's challenges. Within the pedagogical context, an emergent secular conception of this practice, under the auspices of educational psychologists like Langer (1989; 1997), Goleman (2008), Lantieri (2008), Roeser, Skinner, Beers, and Jennings (2012), and Schonert-Reichl and Lawlor (2010) are making headway. Consequently, in keeping with the secular nature of the Western approach to this ancient practice, Mindfulness Training (MT) resources have been adapted to maximize the academic, emotional, physical, psychological, and medical benefits provided by this mind-body discipline.

Furthermore, the results stemming from several mindfulness-based teacher training initiatives suggest that personal training in mindfulness skills can increase teachers' sense of well-being and teaching self-efficacy, as well as their ability to manage classroom behavior and establish and maintain supportive relationships with students (Meiklejohn et al. 2012; Roeser et al., 2012; Soloway et al. 2011). This research is particularly poignant when one addresses the problems of burnout and attrition among beginning teachers, many of whom decide to leave the profession early in their career due to their inability to cope with the increasing complexity and emotional demands of the classroom (Karsenti & Collin, 2013; Montgomery & Rupp, 2005). Teachers indicate that workload, lack of collaborative time with co-workers, lack of support from administration, and managing complex student behaviors comprise some of the most difficult stressors bearing down on them (Roeser et al., 2012). Yet, despite the high distress levels they report, empirical research addressing potential solutions to teachers' work-related stress and burnout is sparse (Jennings, Lantieri, & Roeser, 2011; Poulin et al., 2008).

Acknowledging the increasing evidence base for the efficacy of mindfulness interventions as well as the elevated stress levels reported by many educators and their students, this book discusses and explores how mindful practices, praxis, and research can inform and support pedagogy, curriculum, and leadership initiatives in higher education in the twenty-first century. Alongside the multitude of recent studies in the area of Mindfulness, the authors discuss their own experiences using Self-Study, Contemplative Pedagogy, Living Educational Theory, and Curriculum Inquiry by providing insights into Mindful Education and a Pedagogy of Well-Being. The content of this book examines ways in which to develop habits of mind, courses of action as well as a curriculum of study that would support educators as they cultivate competencies for thriving and coping with the modern demands of being a teacher.

In *Mindfulness Training: A Transdisciplinary Approach to Assessing Efficacy in Education*, Elizabeth R. Mackenzie examines the plethora of research in a variety of clinical contexts as well as the emergent results in the field of education which support the optimal impact of Mindfulness. In keep-

ing with the evidence-based discourses presented, an overview of the various dimensions of Mindfulness Training (MT) from MBSR to MB-EAT is undertaken. In particular, Mackenzie seeks out experimentations which point to the definitive impact of Mindfulness on the neuroplasticity of the brain, executive function, working memory, pro-social behavior, and resilience. She suggests that using this transdisciplinary approach to build an evidence-base for innovations in education has the potential to strengthen pedagogical policy and practice. Providing an extensive amount of references, this chapter serves as a pivotal link in the on-going discussion which contextualizes learning skills and aptitudes within an understanding of the whole person. Substantiated experimentation is proving that programs seeking to improve academic performance need to address not only the cognitive skills of learners, but also the social and emotional dimensions of the individual. Essentially, a quarter of a century of research is proving that contemplative practices like mindfulness training have the ability to enhance academic performance. As proof, Mackenzie refers back to studies that demonstrate in a conclusive manner that the mental training of meditation functions as a skill acquisition to induce plastic changes in the brain impacting cognition, mood, and behavior. In light of the unremitting corroboration of the data, she proposes that a transdisciplinary approach to pedagogy drawing on the wealth of documented scientific studies can support innovative, creative paradigms in emergent educational practice and policy.

In *Mindful Education and Well-Being*, Karen Ragoonaden revisits and introduces new explorations pointing to the optimal impact of Mindfulness in pedagogical contexts. Referring to the literature, she emphasizes the work of Langer (1989; 1997), Rechtschaffen (2014), Schoeberlein and Sheth (2009), and Ritchhart and Perkins (2000) all of whom are proponents of Mindfulness as an educational goal surpassing base instructional techniques and progressing toward meaningful practices impacting the well-being of educators and students. As an ancillary theme, based on her own background and interests, the congruence between Eastern Contemplative practices, Indigenous Wisdom, and Mindfulness are also carefully interwoven into the fabric of the discussion. In keeping with the reflective stance espoused by the emergent methodology of self-study, she embarks on her own self-study examining how the integration of mindfulness in her daily life affects pedagogical practice. Acknowledging the seminal concepts of kindness, compassion, attention, intention, and authenticity as embodied states of mindfulness, the self-study described in this chapter provides a practical portrait of how the progression of a daily mindful practice influenced personal and professional identity, being a reflective practitioner, and the development a holistic vision of teaching. Several well-documented mindfulness practices were used: mindful eating, mindful focus, mindful challenge, and mindful journaling. Using a variety of formal and informal practices, the self-study has been

purposely positioned as a reflective exercise for novice practitioners which can also be integrated as professional and personal development. Considering the wide range of literature from a variety of disciplines and the myriad of methodological perspectives, the author notes that an educational framework specifically aimed at developing Mindfulness in Education would add validity to research in the area of the scholarship of teaching and learning. Recognizing the import of Eastern and Indigenous Wisdom traditions which position the individual at the nexus of intention, there is a recognition that a disposition of mindfulness has to be cultivated in a systemic manner. This acknowledgment of self-determination in the practice is of primordial importance, providing a foundation in the emergence and sustained progression of embodied wisdom impacting the clarity and efficiency of the mind.

In chapter 3, *Enhancing Learning through Contemplative Pedagogy*, Kathryn Byrnes and Tom Bassarear discuss the innovative curricula developed for their respective courses on Mindfulness in Higher Education. Considering that Mindfulness is an important component of Contemplative Pedagogy, they frame their course design around two salient questions: *What distinguishes mindful from mindless education? How do educational models support and/or diminish our capacity for Mindfulness?* Conceding that Contemplative Pedagogy consists of practices that reveal, clarify, and make manifest the nature of the reality of one's mind ("I"), the mind of others ("Thou"), and the world ("It"), they seek to understand the complex relationships existing between the self, the other, and society at large. While much has been written about the features of contemplative inquiry (Hart, 2004; Zajonc, 2009), little has been written about the pedagogical underpinnings of a successful contemplative classroom. Referring to Zajonc (2009), the pedagogical practices are rooted in stages of contemplative inquiry: respect, gentleness, intimacy, participation, vulnerability, transformation, and insight. Byrnes and Bassarear share four categories of practices used to develop these qualities in their course: building community, fostering first person inquiry, creating differentiated learning activities, and assessing holistically. They posit that these instructional techniques can be aligned with particular disciplinary content in unique ways that honor the unity of a contemplative approach to education. Creating an interdependent learning environment requires an invitation for learners to be aware, engaged, and connected to themselves first, and then secondly to their co-learners, who are experiencing the same emergent process. Within the context of a safe and nurturing environment, developing a community of learners while holding onto the individuality and diversity reigning in each person enhances the potential for dialogue and societal transformation. First person inquiry experiences, like observing a plant or piece of art for twenty minutes or bringing mindfulness to their use of technology, facilitates students' connection with their mind-body-emotions and heightens their awareness of human and digital intercon-

nection. Holistically assessing students' understandings and misunderstandings also creates opportunities for more useful and timely feedback. Such assessments inform the scholarship of teaching and learning by providing parameters for successful Mindfulness practices. Nurturing the emergence of Contemplative Pedagogy in higher education curricula requires careful attention to the development of the students' abilities, inclinations, and sensitivities. By cultivating the presence of multiple perspectives in educational contexts, the courses developed by the authors progress towards a shrewd discernment of the value of mindfulness to the detriment of mindlessness in themselves, in others, and in contemporary society.

In chapter 4, *Living Collaborative Leadership: Cultivating a Mindful Approach*, Sabre Cherkowski, Kelly Hanson, and Jennifer Kelly examine how the conceptualization and the application of mindful leadership requires deep, collegial conversations focusing on self-knowledge and an awareness of the complex interconnections of the life-work dichotomy, culminating in a recognition of the higher purpose of educational leadership. By emphasizing collective storytelling (Born, 2014), they aim to position the reflective mind-body discipline of Mindful Leadership in the wake of scholarly discourse and stalwart educational administration. Their shared voices, experiences, and insights pave the way for the ensuing learning journey that is the focus of this chapter. Inspired by Living Educational Theory (Whitehead, 2008), the authors illustrate through research and personalized discourse how collective narratives reflecting on the import of presence, care, curiosity, and interdependence are becoming models of mindful engagement and professional learning. This integrative model of higher education encourages a holistic learning environment in which school leaders flourish and gain knowledge and insight about themselves, their colleagues, their students, and society. Since educational policy is not necessarily seen as the arena for a deeper understanding of self in relation to the social and natural worlds, this chapter offers a new perspective on the juxtaposition of mindfulness practices like *Leaderful Mindsets*, in educational leadership through the collaborative efforts of critical and collective voices.

In chapter 5, *Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education: Pedagogical Insights*, Geoffrey Soloway provides an exemplar of how Kabat-Zinn's (1990) traditional Mindful Based Stress Reduction (MBSR) program can be modified and adapted for teacher candidates enrolled in a Teacher Education program. Within the context of an elective course entitled Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education (MBWE), a formal wellness component was added to emphasize not only the development of Mindfulness but also to enhance well-being. Various methods of practicing mindfulness in the classroom taken from eclectic traditions were incorporated into curricula. In particular, the concept of *flow* (Csikszentmihályi, 1997) was introduced as a precept of physical mindfulness. Similarly to the numerous incarnations of

Mindful Education, self-study is an integral attribute of the course work and is positioned as a metaphor for drawing on past experiences. By learning mindful practices in a committed and engaged manner, teacher candidates, in turn, can introduce strategies for infusing well-being into their classrooms for their students' benefit. Organized into three sections—Assignments (Personal Wellness Book, Mindful Journaling, and Holistic Lesson Plans); Learning Mindfulness; and a Pedagogy of Well-Being—this transformative course models creative and critical frameworks and paradigms for contemporary Teacher Education programs. Concluding with an emphasis on Literacy and Mindfulness, this chapter expands on how innovative approaches to the scholarship of teaching and learning can impact on core curriculum and on inner curriculum in higher education.

In the concluding chapter, *Mindful Curricular Engagement: Preparing Prospective Educators to See/Act with Discernment and Deliberation*, Margaret Macintyre Latta explores how to develop mindfulness as an educational goal for teacher candidates and examines what it means to cultivate mindfulness as an integral movement in curriculum innovation and development. Taking her cue from field experiences, she artfully deconstructs the lived terms of knowledge by pondering the seminal question, *What counts as mindful knowledge?* By virtue of representative accounts of prospective teachers' attempts at mindful curricular engagement, she brings the present's potential to immediate attention. This author posits that curricular enactment provides the framework from which connections and multiple perspectives arise, become visible, and flow through moving minds, bodies, and spirits. Within this aesthetic paradigm, it is important that newly-minted educators nurture an awareness of theory/practice conjectures which marry mindful praxis to curricular enactment. In her quest to reframe education as a curriculum engagement of mindful practice, she points to the importance of developing discernment and deliberation in all aspects of pedagogy. Within this context, Mindful Teaching and Learning become the axiom which cultivates and embraces the possibilities of transformation.

These six chapters offer compelling and thought-provoking discourses seeking to initiate exchanges about sustainable Mindfulness practices in Education. We, the authors, have attempted to share our experiences with authenticity and humility, anticipating that the narratives presented will offer, and possibly embody, alternate, holistic visions and perceptions of teaching, learning, and well-being, infused with kindness, care, and compassion. This, despite the oft chaotic and complex realities of the educational contexts in which we teach, we learn, and we live.

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Chapter One

Mindfulness Training

A Transdisciplinary Approach to Assessing Efficacy in Education

Elizabeth R. Mackenzie

Evidence-based practice is the standard of excellence in many fields, particularly the health sciences. The fields of educational psychology and education policy also call for a robust set of data in which to ground innovations, ensuring that policies and practices are built upon a dependable framework of factually based theory. Recently, an increasing number of studies on mindfulness training (MT) and related contemplative practices from a range of academic disciplines have underscored their relevance for the field of education.

What makes mindfulness training (MT), in particular, so intriguing is that early research suggests that MT can enhance: 1) cognitive skills, 2) brain function, 3) immune system function, 4) emotional regulation and coping with stress, 5) psychological resiliency, 6) pro-social behavior and communication skills, as well as, 7) address some mental health problems and learning disorders. While this may seem like an extravagant claim, neuroimaging studies on contemplative practices point toward a surprising finding: these practices appear to allow us to use our minds to shape our brains across the lifespan and especially in childhood (Zelazo and Lyons 2012). In other words, the mental training of meditation functions as any other skill acquisition to induce plastic changes in the brain (Davidson and Lutz 2008), which in turn shape cognition, mood, and behavior. Assuming these early findings are replicated, it would explain how mindfulness training (and contemplative practices in general) could be a catalyst for improvements in so many disparate areas of evaluation.

THE CONTEMPLATIVE SCIENCE PROJECT

These issues are especially pertinent to the emergent field of contemplative science (Frank et al. 2013). Also referred to as the *Contemplative Science Project* (CSP) (Roeser 2013), it has been described as “an interdisciplinary effort to derive a new understanding of the mind-body system and its prospects for transformation . . . through the lens of mental training and neuroplasticity” (Roeser 2013). Goals of the CSP include developing a comprehensive understanding of the effect of contemplative practices on persons across the lifespan, applying these findings to optimize human development, and evaluating how secularized versions of contemplative practices can be widely implemented to relieve suffering and foster positive development (Roeser 2013; Frank et al. 2013). This transdisciplinary approach to building the evidence-base, *one that transcends academic disciplines*, is crucial to an accurate assessment of mindfulness and other contemplative practices as they are applied to education due to the important scientific studies conducted across many academic fields.

Central to the field of contemplative science is mindfulness or “mindfulness training” (MT) (Roeser 2013). Mindfulness has entered into U.S. discourse largely through the work of Jon Kabat-Zinn, PhD, a molecular biologist who adapted an Eastern meditation practice for clinical settings. He dubbed the clinical intervention Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR), a wholly secular tool designed for clinical populations. MBSR has been tested for three decades in clinical settings and has been demonstrated to provide benefit in a number of areas, including: anxiety, depression, chronic pain, immune system function, heart disease, substance abuse, and eating disorders (Ludwig and Kabat-Zinn 2008). MBSR has been so successful that numerous “spin-off” interventions have been created. These mindfulness-based interventions (MBIs) have made a significant impact on behavioral medicine: Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT), Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy (MBCT), Mindfulness-Based Relapse Prevention (MBRP), Mindfulness-Based Childbirth and Parenting (MBCP), and Mindfulness-Based Eating Awareness Therapy (MB-EAT), to name but a few (Greeson 2009; Cullen 2011). Furthermore, brain-imaging studies performed on persons who meditate have yielded intriguing new findings about brain plasticity, findings that suggest that brain structure, neurocircuitry, and cerebral blood flow all respond over time to mental activity and that this plasticity endures across the lifespan (Fox et al. 2014; Chiesa et al. 2011; Newberg et al. 2010; Lutz et al. 2008). Finally, a subset of studies point to significant benefits of mindfulness practice on focus, attention, working memory, and academic performance (Jha et al. 2007; Mrazek et al. 2013; Tang et al. 2014). All of these studies, though strictly speaking not within the field of education *per se*, clearly have implications for educational practice

and policy. Salient findings from clinical medicine, behavioral medicine, and neuroscience can inform the educational sciences in important ways. It is necessary to look beyond the confines of a single academic discipline when evaluating the efficacy of contemplative practices.

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION AND CONTEMPLATIVE PRACTICES

Adapting traditional Buddhist meditation practices, secular mindfulness was introduced into clinical medicine in the 1980s in the form of Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR) by Jon Kabat-Zinn and his colleagues at the University of Massachusetts (Ludwig and Kabat-Zinn 2008); since that time, it has had a significant impact on psychoneuroimmunology, neuroscience, and especially on behavioral medicine (Baer 2003). Both psychological theory and practice have slowly been transformed by new findings emerging from mindfulness research, and there is now a subfield of study termed “mindfulness psychology” (Felver et al. 2013). Brain imaging studies of persons engaged in meditation suggest that focused mental activities can actually change cerebral blood flow, brain morphology, and neural circuitry, in addition to strengthening the immune system (Davidson et al. 2003) and improving attention skills (Jha et al. 2007). MBSR has been repeatedly documented to be effective in treating mental health problems, particularly depression and anxiety, in numerous adult populations (Baer 2003; Greeson 2009). As Daniel Siegel has pointed out,

Mindful awareness is a profoundly integrative internal process. The observing self is open and receptive to the experiencing self, moment by moment. Research has demonstrated that being present with mindful awareness promotes health across the entire triangle of well-being, involving mind, brain, and relationships. (Siegel 2012)

Now, researchers are testing MBSR and other contemplative practices in children, adolescents, and young adults as a way to treat social-emotional dysfunction as well as to promote health and enhance academic performance (Black et al. 2009; Burke 2009; Greenberg and Harris 2011; Shapiro et al. 2011; Rempel 2012). Prompted by the robust scientific findings of mindfulness as a tool to support physical and mental health in adult populations, several groups have sprung up over the last decade devoted to applying and evaluating mindfulness in K–12 educational settings as well as in higher education, such as the Garrison Institute, Mindful Schools, Mindful Education Institute, Mindfulness in Education Network, and the Association for Contemplative Mind in Higher Education. Teachers across the country are enrolling in mindfulness training programs, administrators are introducing

mindfulness to their schools, and researchers are devising ways to evaluate the effects of mindfulness in cohorts of students and teachers (Ryan 2012; Meiklejohn et al. 2012; MLERN 2012).

As noted by Greenberg and Harris (2011), although mindfulness (and other forms of secular meditation) have been shown to improve physiological and mental health in adult populations, as well as to positively affect brain function and morphology, there has been a dearth of well-designed experimental studies on the effectiveness of school-based mindfulness programs designed to improve academic performance, and the “enthusiasm for promoting such practices outweighs the current evidence supporting them” (Greenberg and Harris 2011). However, much of the preliminary evidence is promising.

PROGRAMS FOR K–12 STUDENTS

Several pilot studies on universal school-based contemplative practices (including yoga and mindfulness) have yielded limited but encouraging results. For example, in an evaluation of a twelve-week yoga and mindfulness-based program for inner-city students (fourth and fifth grades), Mendelson et al. (2010) reported that students in the intervention group showed decreases in involuntary stress responses (specifically, lower scores on rumination, intrusive thoughts, and emotional arousal). A larger-scale study of this program is currently being conducted (Mendelson et al. 2013).

Flook et al. (2010) conducted a randomized controlled trial of an eight-week mindfulness curriculum for elementary school children (the InnerKids Program). The authors report improvements in executive function (EF) in children in the intervention group who had lower baseline EF (using parent and teacher reports). Schonert-Reichl and Lawlor (2010) report on a pilot, nonrandomized, wait-list control study of a mindfulness program for fourth through seventh graders ($n=246$). Compared to controls, the intervention students reported increases in optimism and positive affect, with teacher-reported improvements in pro-social behavior.

Broderick and Metz (2009) evaluated a pilot trial of the Learning to BREATHE Program, a mindfulness-based curriculum developed for adolescents. This study looked at a group of high school girls in the program and found that students in the intervention group ($n=120$) reported increases in calm, relaxation, and self-acceptance when compared with controls ($n=17$). A follow-up study of Learning to BREATHE used a quasi-experimental pre-test and post-test design to evaluate the program in two suburban high schools ($n=216$) (Metz et al. 2013). The results suggest that this curriculum improved emotional regulation, self-regulation efficacy, psychosomatic complaints, and self-reported levels of stress.

Tang et al. (2014) found that a mindfulness-based training for adolescents (n=208) was effective in improving attention and academic performance (104 students were randomized to a mindfulness based group, 104 to an active control that included relaxation techniques only). An RCT of elementary school students (n=194) in a meditation program found that participants had reduced test anxiety and increased selective attention; teachers reported better attention and social skills (Napoli et al. 2005). In a randomized controlled trial of 100 elementary school children (fourth and fifth grades), the mindfulness-based MindUP Program integrated into the curriculum over a four-month period was found to support prosocial behavior, increase feelings of well-being, and improve math grades (Schonert-Reichl et al. 2015).

An evaluation of a mindfulness-based program for sixth-grade students (n=101) in which students were randomized to either a class with mindfulness practice or a class with another experiential activity (the active control group) found that both groups decreased significantly on clinical syndrome scales. Students in the mindfulness class were, however, significantly less likely to report suicidal ideation or thoughts of self-harm (Britton et al. 2014). Parker et al. (2014) evaluated a mindfulness-based program aimed at fourth and fifth grade students designed to decrease intent to use tobacco and alcohol; no significant differences were found in intentions toward substance use comparing the active group to the wait-list control group, though the active group reported significant improvements in executive function skills and there was a reduction in aggression and social problems.

Two recent meta-analyses have been conducted. The first was a review of twenty mindfulness interventions for youth (ages eighteen and younger) that found that mindfulness interventions were helpful with an effect size that was small to moderate in universal interventions, but with a larger effect size when analyzing mindfulness interventions in clinical populations of youth (Zoogman et al. 2014). The authors conclude that future research might best be focused on youth with psychopathological diagnoses in clinical settings (Zoogman et al. 2014). This finding is congruent with the clinical findings of the past three decades; namely, that mindfulness-based interventions (MBIs) are effective for anxiety, depression, and other mental health disorders. The second examined twenty-four studies (Zenner et al. 2014) and determined that despite the heterogeneity in methods and instruments, along with the fact that many studies were statistically underpowered, “mindfulness-based interventions in children and youths hold promise, particularly in relation to improving cognitive performance and resilience to stress” (Zenner et al. 2014).

Three bodies of evidence all point to the promising nature of K–12 school-based mindfulness programs: 1) the large body of data on the effectiveness of mindfulness in adult populations, 2) the small but growing body of data on the effectiveness of mindfulness in children and youth, both universal and clinical populations, and 3) the emerging evidence on the feasibility

ity, acceptability, and efficacy of school-based mindfulness programs. A recent article published in *Psychology in the Schools*, calls for the integration of mindfulness psychology into school psychology interventions using a three-tier approach: 1) universal for the whole school; 2) targeted clinical groups; 3) intensive for individuals with diagnoses of psychopathology (Fellver et al. 2013). The authors note that universal mindfulness interventions can be integrated with existing school-wide social emotional learning (SEL) programs to good effect, an observation supported by others (MLERN 2012; Lawlor 2014).

PROGRAMS FOR K–12 TEACHERS

“Early research results on three illustrative mindfulness-based teacher training initiatives suggest that personal training in mindfulness skills can increase teachers’ sense of well-being and teaching self-efficacy, as well as their ability to manage classroom behavior and establish and maintain supportive relationships with students” (Micklejohn et al. 2012). Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education (MBWE) (Poulin et al. 2008) is an MBI for teachers and other human service professionals being piloted in Canada. MBWE is an eight-week intervention based on MBSR and grounded in the principles set out by Jon Kabat-Zinn (Poulin et al. 2008). Twenty-eight participants and sixteen controls drawn from a cohort of undergraduates in a teacher education program were included in the study. Results included increased mindfulness, life satisfaction, and teacher self-efficacy (Poulin et al. 2008). Stress Management and Relaxation Techniques (SMART) in Education (developed by Cullen and Wallace 2010) was piloted as an intervention for parents and educators of children with special needs and found to significantly improve caregiver competence, as well as to significantly reduce stress and anxiety (Benn et al. 2012). A more recent RCT of the same MT intervention supports these earlier findings. This mindfulness training for teachers (n=113) study found that elementary and secondary teachers randomized to MT had improved focused attention and working memory capacity, as well as greater mindfulness and occupational self-compassion; the intervention group also reported lower levels of occupation stress and burn-out at the three-month follow-up (Roeser et al. 2013). Jennings et al. (2013) evaluated the Cultivating Awareness and Resilience (CARE) Program, a mindfulness-based intervention for teachers with a randomized controlled trial of fifty teachers (assigned to CARE or a waitlist control group). This study found that participants in the intervention group showed improvements in well-being, efficacy, burn-out and mindfulness. The authors discuss the importance of mindfulness-based interventions for cultivating social emotional competence (SEC) in teachers. Frank et al. (2013) used a quasi-experi-

mental pre- and post-test design with a comparison group to test the effects of an eight-week MBSR program in a population of thirty-six high school educators. Findings from this study include gains in self-regulation, self-compassion, sleep quality, and mindfulness-related skills. Abenavoli et al. (2013) did a cross-sectional analysis to determine whether or not mindfulness is negatively related to burnout. The authors found that mindfulness had strong negative associations with emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and low personal accomplishment, all important dimensions of burnout. Mindfulness was also associated with better sleep quality.

Jennings (2014) makes a case for careful consideration of teachers' psychosocial characteristics and how these impact the quality of learning environments, particularly for young children. In this study of thirty-five preschool teachers' self-reports, the author explored how mindfulness, self-compassion, personal efficacy, and positive affect were associated with being better able to offer emotional support to challenging students, while emotional exhaustion, depression, and depersonalization were associated with negative outcomes. These and similar studies underscore the need to better understand how mindfulness-based practices incorporated into teacher professional development programs can support social and emotional competence, thereby improving learning environments.

HIGHER EDUCATION

A burgeoning body of literature is devoted to examining the role of mindfulness and other contemplative practices in higher education, both at the undergraduate and the graduate level (Shapiro et al. 2011; Barbezat and Bush 2014). There are three main rationales for integration of these practices into higher education: 1) stress management, 2) improved academic performance, and 3) "whole person" development (Shapiro et al. 2011: 496); some programs are specifically aimed at one of these goals, while others may embrace all three dimensions.

Numerous Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR) programs have been implemented on college campuses with generally positive results (Astin 1997; Jain et al. 2007; Shapiro et al. 2007; Oman 2008). A meta-analysis of twenty-four cognitive, behavioral, and mindfulness studies conducted in populations of university students found that all these interventions were effective in reducing stress (Regehr et al. 2013). Now there have emerged several new approaches adapted to be most effective and feasible for higher education settings. For instance, Greeson et al. (2014) conducted a randomized-controlled trial of Koru Mindfulness (n=90), a practice designed specifically for emerging adults (ages eighteen to twenty-nine) that condenses the program to four seventy-five-minute sessions, with just ten minutes of home

practice required each night (Rogers 2013). This adaptation was found more effective and feasible with college students than the original MBSR format which requires eight weeks of classes with up to forty-eight minutes of home practice each night. The RCT found that the active group ($n=45$) showed significant improvements in perceived stress and sleep problems and increases in mindfulness, self-compassion, and gratitude. Similarly, a study of mindfulness programs for university students that compared formal versus informal practice, found that formal mindfulness-based stress management techniques produced greater levels of mindfulness, self-compassion, and lower levels of stress (Hindman et al. 2014).

Many mindfulness-based programs have been implemented in health professions training programs (medicine, nursing, and allied health professions), and a growing number are being piloted in schools of law, business, and arts and sciences (Barbezat and Bush 2014). Medical students ($n=140$) participating in an MBSR program showed improvements in mood disturbance compared to controls (Rosenzweig et al. 2003). Kar et al. (2014) describe a mindfulness-based cognitive therapy program for medical students for stress reduction, while Warde et al. (2014) explore the utility of mindfulness to promote leadership and resiliency among medical students at UCLA who work with underserved, vulnerable patients (e.g., prison populations). Song and Lindquist (2014) conducted a study of forty-four nursing students in Korea; twenty-one were randomized to an MBSR group and twenty-three to a wait-list control group. The study found that the MBSR group reported significantly greater reductions in depression, anxiety, and stress, while experiencing increases in mindfulness. Mindfulness-based programs are also being used in health professions training to cultivate self-awareness and reflection, thereby enhancing clinicians' capacity to deliver compassionate, sensitive, patient-centered care (Saunders et al. 2007). Several studies have examined how the cultivation of mindfulness among graduate students in professional mental health training programs can promote empathy, compassion, and good self-care practices (Newsome et al. 2006; Shapiro et al. 2007; Schure et al. 2008; Christopher and Maris 2010).

Finally, there is a movement to promote contemplative practices in general within higher education to enrich the educational experience and to support creative thinking, reflection, and increased self-awareness (Bush 2011; Shapiro et al. 2011; Sarath 2003). The American Council of Learned Societies initiated the Contemplative Practice Fellowship program in 1997, contributing to the integration of contemplative practices at over seventy-five colleges and universities (Sarath 2003). Some notable examples include Brown University's Concentration in Contemplative Studies that is open to both undergraduate and graduate students (<http://www.brown.edu/academics/contemplative-studies/>), the Contemplative Inquiry and Approaches in Education Masters program at Simon Fraser University (<http://www.sfu.ca/edu->

cation/gs/degreediploma/masters/ci-cpa2014.html) and the University of Virginia, which recently established a Contemplative Sciences Center (<http://uvacontemplation.org/>) with participation from the Curry School of Education, the Darden School of Business, and the Schools of Medicine and Nursing. In addition to supporting general student well-being, these types of initiatives seek to enhance metacognition, creativity, and transformative learning (Shapiro et al. 2011).

BRAIN IMAGING AND COGNITIVE FUNCTION STUDIES

As noted above, a subset of studies on contemplative practices has focused on their impact on cognitive function. Jha et al. (2007) found that mindfulness meditation practice improved focus and attention among a cohort of college students. Specifically, the authors explored three subsystems of attention: alerting, orienting, and conflict monitoring. Two different cohorts were studied, one group newly introduced to MT (via an eight-week MBSR course), the other more experienced. The study found that concentrative attention (focused attention) improved in the less experienced group, while the more experienced cohort exhibited greater receptive attention (open-monitoring). Mrazek et al. (2013) examined mindfulness training (MT) as an intervention for reducing mind wandering by randomizing forty-eight male and female undergraduate students to either a two-week mindfulness class or a two-week class on nutrition. They tested working memory capacity (WMC) pre- and post-intervention, along with administering a verbal-reasoning section from the GRE. The authors report that this two-week MT intervention resulted in increased working memory capacity and superior reading comprehension on the GRE (Mrazek et al. 2013). Among the notable findings of this study is that merely two weeks of MT produced measurable improvements in cognitive function, a considerably shorter period of time than the eight-week MBSR intervention and other similar MBIs.

Chiesa et al. (2010) conducted a meta-analysis of twenty-three studies on mindfulness and cognition. Overall, this review suggests that mindfulness can improve cognition (e.g., working memory capacity, attention) and executive function, though the authors caution that some of the studies included had methodological weaknesses, which subsequent studies should address.

What could account for these changes in cognition? A number of neuroimaging studies indicate that meditation practice can have an influence on the brain itself. Experienced meditators appear to exhibit beneficial changes in cerebral blood flow (CBF) (Newberg et al. 2010), and enhancements in the neurocircuitry associated with empathy and compassion (Lutz et al. 2008). Even a relatively modest eight weeks of MBSR has been shown to result in increases in the brain circuitry associated with positive affect (the anterior

left-side of the brain), along with improved immunity (Davidson et al. 2003). Lazar et al. (2005) report that areas of the cerebral cortex (the prefrontal cortex and right anterior insula) were thicker in meditators compared with matched controls; Hölzel et al. (2011) found that grey matter in other areas of the brain, such as the hippocampus, was denser in persons who meditate. It also appears that the amygdala (the part of the brain which registers threat and activates the “flight or fight” response) may exhibit decreased gray matter density in those who meditate compared to those who do not, a neurological correlate of being less reactive to perceived threat (Hölzel et al. 2010). One recent study found a correlation between dispositional mindfulness and decreased amygdala gray matter volume in a sample of 155 adults, providing further evidence for a link between mindfulness and decreased threat reactivity (Taren et al. 2013).

A meta-analysis by Fox et al. (2014) of twenty-one neuroimaging studies found convergent findings pointing to alterations in structure in eight specific areas of the brain related to: meta-awareness, body awareness, memory, self/emotional regulation, and intra- and inter-hemispheric communication with the brain. “These preliminary findings suggest that, due to the brain’s neuroplastic nature (i.e., its ability to create new neurons and neural connections), individuals can actively change their brain structure in ways that promote brain health and improve the quality of one’s life” (Meiklejohn et al. 2012). Zelazo and Lyons (2012) suggest that the emerging evidence “bodes well for the possibility that age-appropriate mindfulness practices may be beneficial for children, with concurrent and cascading benefits for academic and social success” particularly in the area of self-regulation.

Although the neuroscience of MT is still in its infancy, a picture is emerging that suggests:

1. Contemplative practices can positively affect brain circuitry, structure, and cerebral blood flow.
2. Mindfulness can improve attention, focus, executive function, and working memory.
3. Mindfulness can address deficits in social skills, behavior, and communication.
4. Mindfulness can decrease mental health problems (e.g., anxiety, depression) and increase positive affect and resilience.

Increasingly, scientific findings have shown that the human brain is responsive to both thoughts and emotions and that brain plasticity, although most pronounced in infancy, persists throughout childhood and into adulthood: “The human brain remains open to changing in response to experience throughout the lifespan” (Siegel 2012). Given these findings, it is incumbent upon educational policy makers to support activities known to shape the

brain in positive ways, enhancing self-regulation, empathy, and other dispositions linked to prosocial behavior, as well as cognition. Evidence suggests that social and emotional wellbeing is closely linked to learning (Durlak et al. 2011), and that ignoring the “heart-mind connection” may lead to behavioral dysfunction, antisocial dynamics, and poor academic outcomes in both K–12 (MLERN 2012) and higher education settings (Smeets et al. 2014; Neff et al. 2005). Understanding the physiological underpinnings, or the biomechanical pathways, of the mind-body connection can help education researchers and policy makers better utilize robust scientific findings from other fields of research to optimize student wellbeing and success. This transdisciplinary approach to building an evidence-base for innovations in education has the potential to strengthen educational policy and practice in the same way that multivalent perspectives can enrich our understanding of any phenomenon. By examining pertinent findings from a range of disciplines, a three-dimensional picture emerges, one that is more complete because it is informed by findings from multiple disciplines. While conducting studies in the contemplative sciences in school-age populations and in school-based settings is crucial, we should also not lose sight of the larger scientific context in which these explorations are conducted.

A TRANSDISCIPLINARY APPROACH

Just as the health care sector is adapting to new information about the biomechanical pathways that link mind to body (McCabe-Ruff and Mackenzie 2009), so the field of conventional pedagogical theory is responding to the work of Gardner, Goleman, and others that contextualizes learning skills and aptitudes within an understanding of the whole person (including relationships, emotions, and neurological systems) (Shapiro et al. 2011; Hyland 2014). This body of research strongly suggests that programs seeking to improve academic performance should address social and emotional dimensions of learning, in addition to cognitive skills, and that contemplative practices have the potential to enhance academic performance, promote prosocial behavior, and possibly even prevent disease and dysfunction.

Taking a transdisciplinary approach to building the evidence base by drawing on many years of scientific exploration in a variety of populations and through the lens of many disciplines may allow a fuller picture to emerge more swiftly thus supporting important, and much needed, innovations in educational practice and policy. Our students need innovations that are firmly grounded in solid scientific findings drawn from all relevant academic disciplines, including clinical medicine and nursing, neuroscience, developmental psychology, clinical psychology, school psychology, and counseling psychology, as well as education and its subfields. While the research on

contemplative practices in education may be nascent, there are other salient fields of study that should inform educational policy and practice. By taking a transdisciplinary approach to assessing the evidence we can gain a more complete understanding of the potential for contemplative practices in general, and mindfulness training in particular, to support innovations in pedagogy for children, youth, and young adults thereby enhancing learning, health, well-being, and positive human development.

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Chapter Two

Mindful Education and Well-Being

Karen Ragoonaden

*Reminiscent of ancient practices of awareness, practical wisdom refers to
Being awake, being intentional, being attentive,
Mindfulness offers the promise of abandoning the lure of complexity
to embrace the dynamic simplicity of being present.¹*

As indicated in the previous chapter, Mindfulness Training (MT), having receiving mainstream acceptance in scientific and societal contexts, is a reflective mind-body practice that is now recognized as a means to not only enhance academic performance, but also to support the various facets of well-being in educational contexts. The concept of mindfulness can be described as the human capacity for observation, participation, and acceptance of life's moments from a loving, compassionate stance. From its traditional emphasis on contemplation and meditation, contemporary practice includes paying attention and being aware of one's everyday activities such as seeing, breathing, writing, walking, reading, drinking, eating, and sitting. In keeping with the previous chapter's call for evidence-based results attesting to the positive impact of mindfulness in pedagogical contexts, this chapter examines the experience of using promising mindful practices for improving education for both educators and students. As an ancillary theme, the congruence between Eastern Contemplative practices, Indigenous Wisdom, and Mindfulness will be discussed. To conclude, a brief overview of my own self-study as a teacher educator exploring mindfulness practices in my daily professional and personal life will be presented.

Two very different historical antecedents have impacted the contemporary progression of mindfulness in educational spheres: traditional spiritual practices stemming from Eastern meditative customs like Buddhism, Hinduism, and Taoism as well as a more secular and behavioral approach developed by psychologist Ellen Langer (1989; 1997). Within Langer's perspec-

tive, the focus is placed on external stimuli, noticing the environment and progressing away from a mindless, passive attitude to a mindful, careful, and intentional stance. In this case, the individual is meant to alter behavior, thus the focus on behaviorism. Within the Buddhist conception of mindfulness, the individual observes the inner and outer environment without judgment or attachment and simply accepts the experience as is (Albrecht, Albrecht & Cohen, 2012; Ritchart & Perkins, 2000). In the face of this dichotomy, it is imperative that educators engage in and comprehend mindfulness within the wide scope in its epistemic, ontological, empirical, and ethical dimensions.

MINDFULNESS

Described as “the awareness that emerges through paying attention on purpose, in the present moment, and non-judgmentally to the unfolding of experience moment by moment” (Kabat-Zinn, 1990 p. 4), the reflective body-mind practice of mindfulness can support the often stressful and challenging contexts of teaching and learning. Twenty-five years ago, Kabat-Zinn’s (1990) seminal work in the Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR) program provided the necessary scientific parameters to evaluate the first structured mindfulness program. Extensive evidence from empirical studies done in science-based areas like neuroscience, medicine, psychology, and healthcare have demonstrated the positive benefits of mindfulness practices in reducing stress and improving physical and mental health outcomes (Baer, 2003; Grossman, Niemann, Schmidt, & Walach, 2004; Shapiro & Carlson, 2009). Secular in nature, mindfulness-based training allows the individual to develop the ability to focus through breathing exercises which promote increased awareness and attention. Given the success of mindfulness interventions with a range of populations, it is logical to explore how this type of training can impact on a pedagogy of well-being for educators and their students who work in high stress environments.

In keeping with the long tradition of research, Rechtschaffen (2014) skillfully documents the nefarious effects of stress on the brain: degradation of the executive functions of the prefrontal cortex (problem-solving, creativity, reasoning), the activity of the hippocampus (learning, memory, emotional regulation), and the amygdalae (reactivity centers). As a longtime advocate of mindfulness and an avid practitioner, he promotes the adoption of attentional exercises that can counter the toxicity of stress. He also describes the qualities of a mindful teacher which arise naturally out of a committed mindfulness practice devoted to nurturing compassion, attention, and authenticity. He postulates that the embodied states of compassion, attention, and authenticity, can become enduring traits which solidify the essential ingredients of a mindful class.

Schoeberlein and Sheth (2009) state that “master teachers are mindful teachers aware of themselves and attuned to their students” (p. 1). In discussing the positive impact of mindfulness on educators and students, they provide, as an ancillary theme, a series of formal and informal practices which guide a mindful practice. In keeping with previous writings (Albrecht et al., 2012; Kabat-Zinn, 1990; Shapiro, Carlson, Astin, & Freedman, 2006), the authors identify a couple of core mindfulness concepts: intention, attention, and attitude. Intention is instrumental in providing the practice with parameters for success. Attention involves suspending judgement and observing thoughts and feelings in an objective and concentrated manner. Finally, a loving kindness attitude stemming from a compassionate state of being provides a solid framework upon which to build a non-judgemental stance.

Seligman (1992), recognized as the founder of positive psychology, speaks to the importance of learned optimism, an essential trait of happiness, and, consequently, well-being. Nielson (2008), referring to Seligman, addresses the discrepancy of what we teach our children and what we want for our children. He begins his international conference presentations, by asking half of the audience one of two questions: *What do schools teach?* and, *What do we want for our children?* Experience demonstrates that participants who respond to the question of what schools teach use terminology like *knowledge, facts, content*. The others, who respond to the question of what we want for our children identify *happiness, well-being, health, kindness, love*. In face of this recurring dichotomy between what schools teach and what we want for students, Neilson poses the seminal question: why are well-being, happiness and kindness not a part of, and in support of, the normal curriculum? This is a valid query that is being broached more and more by a growing number of educators.

For example, in 2013, Professor George Saunders delivered a convocation speech at Syracuse University, which focused on the need for kindness and the necessity of moving away from selfishness and success at all costs. He addresses the *failures of kindness* with equanimity and nonjudgement, and reminds the graduates to *err in the face of kindness*. Reprinted in the *New York Times*, Dr. Saunders’s speech eventually evolved into a bestselling book entitled, *Congratulations by the Way: Some Thoughts on Kindness* (2014).

Twenty years of experimental research led by Langer (1989; 1997) has also demonstrated conditions under which mindfulness can emerge. These studies demonstrate that an open and creative state of consciousness can be developed in the short term. In keeping with these results, Ritchhart and Perkins (2000) question what it takes to inculcate mindfulness as a long-term practice and ponder how to nurture a personal disposition toward mindfulness. They posit that if mindfulness is to be an educational goal, then these practices have to be more than instructional techniques and must be meaningful and have a long-term effect on teachers’ and students’ well-being.

RELATING MINDFULNESS TO A PEDAGOGY OF WELL-BEING

According to Moliver (2010), well-being is a dimension of health enhancement which applies to physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual dimensions. This is consistent with the definition of health put forward by the World Health Organization (1946): “Health is a state of optimal physical, mental and social well-being and not merely the absence of disease and infirmity.” Since, historically, the well-being model represents health in terms of maximizing one’s potential, there is always the possibility of becoming healthier by actively enhancing wellness strategies which become an integral part of classroom behaviour, experiences, culture, and systems.

Research indicates that well-being is an integral component of educational success promoting creativity, capability, and productivity (Nielson, 2008; Seligman 2002). Reflecting on the import of the inner curriculum of classrooms, Lantieri (2008) acknowledges that the field of education must not only pay attention to the inner lives of teachers and students but also give them pedagogical tools designed to cultivate skills that foster inner calm and resilience. Similarly, Goleman (2008), emphasizing the importance of social and emotional resiliency, supports the nurturing of mindful teaching and learning practices in educational contexts. By cultivating the potential of mindful awareness the significant values of personal growth, learning, moral living, and caring for others are also nurtured (Roeser, Peck, & Nasir, 2006). Previous studies indicate that mindfulness-trained teachers embody behaviors and attitudes through their presence and interaction with students in the classroom and through this practice develop an increased sense of well-being and self-efficacy leading to increased clarity and stability of attention (Flook et al., 2013; Poulin, Mackenzie, Soloway, & Karaoylas, 2008; Roeser et al., 2012).

Acknowledging the seminal concepts of kindness, compassion, attention, intention, and authenticity as embodied states of mindfulness and recognizing the optimal impact of mindfulness practices in education, the self-study described in this chapter will provide a practical portrait of the impact of mindfulness on pedagogy and on well-being. Using a variety of formal and informal practices, my self-study has been purposely positioned as a reflective exercise for novice practitioners which can also be integrated as professional and personal development.

SELF-STUDY AND MINDFULNESS

Self-study is acknowledged as an emergent methodology in teacher educators’ personal and professional growth characterized through its self-initia-

tion and focus on improvement (LaBoskey, 2007). Through this approach, educators can examine self-knowing and professional identity formation in their practice and its impact on student learning. This type of critical reflection provides opportunities for modelling reflection and seeking alternate rhetoric to improve practice (Samaras, Hicks, & Garvey Berger, 2007). Since self-study is founded upon the belief that teaching is fundamentally an autobiographical act, self-knowledge is important for transforming pedagogy and practice. Researchers acknowledge that when reflection is missing from teacher education programs, teacher candidates adopt a technocratic rational approach in the classroom, unaware of the impact of the pedagogical and moral consequences of their actions (Gay, 2003; Heilman, 2003; hooks, 1994; LaBoskey, 2007; Pinnegar, 1998). As a unique form of reflection, self-study can delve into unexamined assumptions, privileges, and beliefs forging new ways of understanding the self in the world juxtaposed with the multiplicity of perspectives that alternately inform or deform practice. Tidwell and Fitzgerald's (2006) work relating to the impact of self-study on teaching recognizes the importance of the cyclical process of planning, action, observation, and evaluation on curriculum. Cyclical research processes also are consistent with Creswell's (2002) description of research as a "'spiral' of activities" that is intentional, focused, practical, collaborative, and dynamic (p. 586).

According to Pinnegar & Hamilton (2009), a self-study of teacher education practice allows the researcher to "experience . . . practice in a holistic way constantly aware of the layers that our historical, cultural, personal and professional lives intertwine" (p. 47). This systemic approach in self-study facilitates the exploration of relationships between concentric circles of society, education, and the self. Adler (1956) proposed that holism (the indivisibility of self) and purposiveness were central to understanding human behavior, and that such understanding required an "emphasis on the whole rather than the elements, the interaction between the whole and parts, and the importance of man's (*sic*) social context" (Ansbacher & Ansbacher, 1967, pp. 11–12).

SELF-STUDY, MINDFULNESS, AND WISDOM TRADITIONS

Self-study's holistic approach to self-exploration is a natural pathway toward integrating and interconnecting principles of concepts of mindfulness and well-being into educational practice. Interestingly, it is also reminiscent of Wisdom traditions found in Aboriginal epistemology, particularly the Medicine Wheel of Learning as well as Eastern contemplative practices like Yoga, which seek the union between the mind and body. Similarly to the Vedic

tradition of Yoga, Four Arrows, Cajete, and Lee (2010) explore how Indigenous Wisdom can offer credible accounts of human behavior as it relates to living in balance and harmony with other living systems. Building on the debate surrounding the viability of brain research, they introduce the concept of *Indigenous Wisdom* (p. xi), a holistic and inductive way of perceiving the world. They affirm that a collaborative interdisciplinary approach juxtaposing neuroscience with ancient wisdom can transform human social systems and offer sustainable alternatives for future societies.

For example, the Medicine Wheel of Learning, one aspect of Aboriginal pedagogy, focuses on the state of being of the individual by addressing the person's location in relation to family, individual, community, and nation contexts (Elliott, Halonen, Akiwenzie-Damm, Methot, & George, 2004; Preston, 2011; Walker, 2001; Whiskeyjack, 2000). "The centre of the Medicine determination. This point is said to reflect the will of a person or group to influence the course of their lives" (Bopp, Bopp, Brown, & Lane, 1985/2004, p. 5).

Within the scope of its numerous interpretations, there is recognition that the Medicine Wheel acts as a holistic representation of self-knowledge in the form of a circle or spiral and "symbolizes unity, wholeness, continuation, perpetuity, inseparability, completeness, balance, security, equality, comfort, and health" (Loiselle & McKenzie, 2006, p. 11). Epistemologically, the Medicine Wheel suggests that each of the four dimensions of the circle must be in equilibrium and developed equally in order for an individual to be healthy and well-balanced. By providing direction and guidance for understanding lived experiences, Battiste (2002) describes indigenous knowledge as "an adaptable, dynamic system based on skills, abilities, and problem-solving techniques that change over time depending on environmental conditions" (p. 11). This holistic approach to well-being, teaching, and learning is contrary to Eurocentric pedagogical modes based on linear progression and individualism marred with intense competition.

Due to its emphasis on mind and body, Yoga, like the Medicine Wheel of Learning, is an ancient conceptualization that is well-suited to the sustainable emergence and development of mindful dispositions (Kabat-Zinn, 1990). Yoga is a practice that incorporates a holistic approach to physical activity by focusing on overall mind-emotional-body-spiritual connections through *pranayama* (breath-control exercises), *asana* (physical yoga), and *chanda* (meditation). Modelled upon the world of fauna and flora, the physical postures of Yoga reflect a natural flow in movement, breath, mind, heart, and spirit. Mindful movement is based on a series of yogic asanas (postures) that serve the multiple aspects of the mind and body (Kabat-Zinn, 1990). In light of this, Yoga, a practice which utilizes mental and physical exercises, is a natural pedagogical extension of Mindful Education. Like the Medicine Wheel, Yoga provides a holistic, transformative approach to the human real-

ity and to our interactions with the world. Consequently, Yoga, within a mindful framework, can positively impact the educational context by creating interconnectedness and interdependency between the multiple realities of educational behaviors, experiences, cultures, and systems.

The methodology of self-study, which situates the self in the center of knowledge and experience has much in common with the cyclical principles of the Medicine Wheel and Yogic traditions. Both these approaches can be conceptualized as a teaching tool for educators and students seeking mindful practices by providing parameters for developing self-knowledge, accessing education, and improving practice in a complex, dynamic system.

MINDFULNESS IN PRACTICE

As stated, the self-study described in this chapter will be purposely positioned as a reflective practice for teacher educators emphasizing kindness, compassion, attention, intention, and authenticity as viable and sustainable dispositions. In keeping with the literature advocating a long term personalized practice, I recognized that I had to embody the attributes and to develop a sustained practice prior to engaging in a pedagogy reflecting mindfulness in action. Recognizing my Eastern roots and my adherence to my yoga practice, I began my self-study by observing how the progression of a daily mindful practice impacted on personal and professional identity, on becoming a reflective practitioner, and on developing a holistic vision of teaching. I contextualized my mindfulness practice within a specific course *Introduction to Academic Pedagogy: An Aboriginal Perspective* and examined how the act of ensuring my professional well-being impacted on my practice and my life.

Since mindfulness's focus on attention and awareness is considered to be an innate and inherent human quality, this practice can be easily integrated into many aspects of educators' lives. Accepting that mindfulness can be practiced in either an informal or formal manner any time of day or night in a variety of contexts, I chose to embark on a combination of formalized and informalized practices. Taking my lead Yogic traditions and Indigenous Wisdom, I focused on proven mindfulness activities (Albrecht et al., 2012; Battiste, 2002; Rechtschaffen, 2014; Schoeberlein & Sheth, 2009). My aim was to nurture acts of kindness and compassion by being attentive, intentional and authentic in my personal and professional actions. In particular, I engaged in the following practices over the course of one university semester.

1. Mindful Eating (five minutes, three times a week).
2. Mindful Focus (apply mindfulness to an activity that I do regularly).

3. Mindful Challenge (apply mindfulness to a typically mindless activity).
4. Mindful Journaling (daily observations and reflections).

For three months, I was committed to a variation of the above mindful practices. During this time, daily reflections categorized according to the mindful attributes of intention and attention; compassion and kindness and authenticity as a reflective practitioner were noted. I completed the Five Facet Mindfulness Questionnaire (FFMQ, Baer et al., 2006) at the beginning of the semester and at the end of the semester. Found in the public domain, the FFMQ self-administered psychometric instrument has been used in many mindfulness studies. It is based on a factor analytic study of five independently developed mindfulness questionnaires. The analysis identified five factors that represent five facets of mindfulness: observing, describing, acting with awareness, non-judging of inner awareness, and nonreactivity to inner experience (Awake Mind, <http://www.awakemind.org/quiz.php>).

I began my day with a fifteen-minute meditative practice (mindful focus), followed by five minutes of mindful eating. During the course of the week, I participated in three to four early morning yoga classes. Mindful challenges were done daily and consisted of applying focus and attention to a mundane and/or mindless task, like emptying the dishwasher, or sometimes during challenging and/or stressful professional situations like faculty meetings.

In keeping with the narrative aspect of self-study, the following sections represent the summary of the themes identified in my journal regarding the development of intention and attention; compassion and kindness; and authenticity as a reflective practitioner in my personal and professional lived lives and developing a holistic vision of teaching.

Intention and Attention

As my mindfulness practice progressed, the task of beginning my day sitting cross-legged in a quiet room with an open view to sun, air, and nature allowed me to gather my thoughts and contemplate the unfolding of the moments of my life. Followed by a slow, five-minute practice of eating breakfast, I began my day with a clear head, open heart, and an elongated spine, free of discomfort. Every second day, I would participate in a yoga practice at a studio close to my home. This opening mindfulness practice was an important component in my daily rituals. I recognized that if my practice lapsed, I would become a little off-balance, demonstrating less patience, less focus, and experiencing some level of physical discomfort in my spine and lower back. In keeping with previous research results (Baer, 2003; Grossman et al., 2004; Shapiro & Carlson, 2009), my daily reflections noted that this sustained practice had a positive impact in reducing stress and improving

physical and mental health outcomes. For example, throughout the day, when I would encounter stressful situations, I would come back to my meditative breath, inhale deeply, relax, and then respond to the situation at hand. Furthermore, my ability to focus became sharper, allowing me to deconstruct problems, explore options, and react in a calm manner. This heightened focus also impacted on my academic productivity, allowing me to write in an efficient manner, to teach effectively, and to respond to students' needs in an objective manner without becoming embroiled in emotions and judgement.

In order to alleviate concerns about the qualitative nature of self-study, the FFMQ (Baer et al., 2006) completed at the beginning and at the end of the study, corroborated the progress of my mindful disposition in my professional and personal contexts. As I reflected back, I recognized that I had intuitively incorporated sustainable elements of mindfulness which had impacted on my well-being. For example, after three months of a mindful practice, I naturally drifted toward nutritionally balanced meals, an easy sleep, demonstrated more patience in my personal life, engaged in regular physical activity, was actively participating in intellectual endeavors, and social events with friends and colleagues. This instrument validated the progression and made me more aware of the status of my well-being within a mindfulness practice.

Compassion and Kindness

The act of incorporating mindfulness into my daily life and the ensuing cultivation of a more mindful way of being did enable me to gain a new compassion of my teaching habits impacting my personal and my professional identity. For example, I chose to explore how a mindful practice would affect my experience teaching a first year developmental course aimed at Aboriginal Access students. EDUC 104, *Introduction to Academic Pedagogy: An Aboriginal Perspective* was representative of two years of hard, developmental and administrative work. The approach in EDUC 104 represented a progression toward a holistic pedagogy emphasizing unity and interconnection with all aspects of the self (emotional, intellectual, physical, and spiritual). On the mornings when I would teach, my mindful practice would focus on how to use the concentric, circular approach of the Medicine Wheel of Learning in a developmental course. This specific focus facilitated the development of a holistic educational praxis within paradigms set by the indigenization of knowledge.

Written observations in my journal promoted reflections on my own pedagogy. I recognized that my lived and professional experiences were very different to the sometimes harsh realities of the students I was teaching. Through conversations, I realized that many of these young people, some far from heart and hearth, suffered from anxiety and depression. Economic woes

and an endemic sense of otherness and marginalization further exacerbated the challenges they faced. Delving into my personal life history (Cole & Knowles, 1993), I sought out a connection, an affinity that could provide a foundation upon which to understand implicitly the circuitous path of the Wheel of Medicine. Could I establish a connection and an empathetic understanding with students through a holistic, interconnected approach to teaching? From my privileged position as a university educator, I reflected upon the journey undertaken by these first year students in a nonjudgmental and compassionate manner. My mindful practice and ensuing embodied practice provided me with the stability and the clarity to move away from my judgmental behaviours and to accept without equanimity the choices that had been made regarding attendance, accountability, and responsibility. As one Elder gently reminded me, being at university was an individual choice that could not be foisted upon another. The nexus of the Medicine Wheel of Learning resides in the individual's volition to make decisions that are in harmony with the four states of being. Only when equilibrium is attained does the journey begin.

Authenticity as a Reflective Practitioner

Due to my morning exercise emphasizing mindful focus, I was able to objectively examine analyze my epistemology and my praxis. I reflected on many questions: Within the scope of a culturally relevant first year course, had I managed to adapt my pedagogy to the approach espoused by the Aboriginal Medicine Wheel of Learning, an integral component of this course? By applying precepts of the Medicine Wheel as outlined in *The Sacred Tree* (Bopp et al., 1985/2004) to the cycle of learning, this developmental course should have been providing an opportunity for students to appropriate academic skills in a culturally relevant manner. In this way, students could apply their cultural background to the acquisition of new knowledge and skills necessary for tertiary education. This knowledge construction would, in theory, translate to a successful university experience leading to retention and degree completion. However, using the Medicine Wheel of Learning as a pedagogical approach was a challenging and complex enterprise. Prior to every class, I came back to the important consideration of *interconnectivity*, and the fact that Aboriginal worldviews were important discourses aimed at fostering academic success for First Nations Peoples (Claypool & Preston, 2011). Despite the fact that I had developed, in collaboration with institutional and community partners, a unique, innovative course based on a holistic curriculum, I considered the cultural relevancy of having a non-Aboriginal instructor teaching indigenous-based pedagogies. This unequivocal realization came about in circular manner, the fruit of my early morning ruminations and the attention and ever-growing awareness given to my pedagogical practice.

MINDFULNESS: A HOLISTIC VISION OF TEACHING

As I modify the course for a September delivery, the act of revising combined with the freedom to reflect on course content has paved the way toward a deeply satisfying personal and professional development. This journey has allowed me to experience the act of teaching on a visceral, embodied level exploring how emotion, intellect, physicality, and spirituality interconnect and dissect. Using my daily reflections as a guide, juxtaposed with critical internal conversations, has provided me with the clarity of mind to make sound revisions and culturally relevant decisions which have impacted positively on my students and my practice. By incorporating a collaborative and institutional and community partnership model into the EDUC 104, this holistic vision of teaching and learning has become an integral component of my practice in first year courses. Recognizing the cultural relevancy of circles of learning, of interconnectivity, and of establishing balance between all aspects of the self, has transformed my practice away from a linear trajectory to one that embraces the dichotomy of traditional and nontraditional approaches, making circles out of squares, seeking alternate ways of teaching and learning.

Substantiated by the methodology of self-study, this chapter has explored the development of mindful teaching and a pedagogy of well-being. Evidence of my reframed and reconceptualized praxis through self-examination using a reflective journal and the FFMQ (Baer et al., 2006) became tantamount to understanding and accepting alternative concepts of knowledge, like mindfulness, in educational contexts. Alvin Toffler (1970) speaks to the significance of twenty-first century learners and educators of unleashing their own capacity to *learn, unlearn, and relearn*. In fact, he states that “the illiterate of the 21st century are those who cannot adapt.” This ability to adapt, modify, and change, has long been recognized as a salient factor in the evolutionary success of the human race (Darwin, 1862).

Similarly to precepts found in Mindfulness practices, Indigenous, and Eastern Wisdom traditions, new learning is, thus, enhanced by challenging previously held assumptions, and by accepting in a non-judgmental manner the multiple perspectives of the other (Bullough & Pinnegar, 2001; Pinnegar & Hamilton, 2009). The use of self-study as an approach to reflect on mindfulness practices provided a means to think about, to understand and to develop teachers’ practice within a compassionate, kind, intentional, attentive, and authentic paradigm. Grounded in social constructivist learning theory, self-study interrogates the intersection of theory and practice, research and pedagogy, the self and the other, with the intent to discover hidden personal narratives about education, school, and schooling, and their impact on the way teachers teach. Furthermore, the conceptual analysis of self-study

within the framework of a mindfulness practice promotes excellence in teaching and learning by providing alternate rhetoric for the teacher/educator and a common meeting ground for students coming from non-traditional backgrounds.

In keeping with the literature, results derived from this inquiry also demonstrated how mindfulness skills increased a sense of well-being and self-efficacy, leading to increased clarity and stability of attention. By embodying and practicing mindfulness in my life, I was able to develop skills which increased a sense of physical, emotional, and intellectual well-being. In light of this, I would suggest that the mindfulness practices emphasizing kindness and authenticity, developing focus, and identifying challenge are informal practices which can easily be integrated into the daily personal and professional lives of educators.

We all possess the human capacity for observation, participation, and acceptance of life's moments from a loving, compassionate stance. The challenge for individuals is to embody and to apply these precepts in a sustainable manner in our daily lives. To this extent, Mindfulness is not new. As Four Arrows et al. (2010) state, it is an integral component of ancient wisdom found in Indigenous and Eastern Contemplative practices. Simply put, mindfulness is an innate and inherent human disposition that, like our intellect, emotions, and physical selves, has to be developed, nurtured, and supported with intention and compassion.

Now, in the Western World, as we embrace this time-worn concept, we seek to deconstruct, to analyze, and to apply methodic parameters to this precept. Recognizing the importance of ensuring parameters for daily practice in the harried lives of teachers, Albrecht et al. (2012) propose that a specific framework developed for educational settings can make this process simpler. Considering the wide range of literature from a variety of disciplines and the myriad of methodological perspectives, an educational framework would add not just validity but also comprehensibility to research as well as the practice of Mindfulness in the area of the scholarship of teaching and learning (Rechtschaffen, 2014; Schoeberlein & Sheth, 2009). Notwithstanding Langer's (1989; 1997) work which demonstrated the conditions under which mindfulness can flourish, there are many educational models to choose from. For example, Lantieri's (2008) more recent work builds upon this foundation by providing practical parameters for resiliency. Innovative curriculums like BREATHE, MIND UP, and SMART also support the endorsement of infrastructures in educational contexts. Despite these formalized instructional models, there is a recognition that a disposition of mindfulness has to be cultivated in an intentional manner by the individual. This acknowledgment of self-determination in the practice is of primordial importance providing a foundation in the emergence and sustained progression of embodied mindfulness practice. On a last note, I turn to the wise sages of

Eastern Wisdom traditions whose simple words belie the complex challenges of engaging in and being committed to mindful practices steeped in authenticity, reflection, kindness, compassion, care, and awareness. . . . “*Put your heart, mind, intellect and soul even into your smallest acts. This is the secret of success*” (Sivananda).

NOTE

1. Quote from author’s unpublished poem.

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Chapter Three

Enhancing Learning Through Contemplative Pedagogy

Kathryn Byrnes and Tom Bassarear

In his call for renewal in higher education, Zajonc (2010) addresses the triumvirate of experience, contemplation, and transformation. Zajonc, a professor of physics who has written extensively about Goethe's science contributions, decries the fact despite decades of research in developmental psychology and neuroplasticity, educators seldom incorporate pedagogy from "best practices" research in their teaching. Furthermore, tertiary institutions rarely embrace transformative views of pedagogy, becoming, instead, bogged down in the quagmire of tradition and the status quo. Contemplative pedagogy, with its focus on teaching methods designed to cultivate deepened awareness, concentration, and insight, fosters other ways of knowing and experiencing ourselves, others, and the world in which we live. Complementing rational, linear educational perspectives with creative and critical approaches, this form of inquiry is positioned as a new paradigm for the scholarship of teaching and learning through refined attention emphasizing direct experience, contemplation, and transformation.

Heeding the call for renewal in university curricula, our chapter contributes to the transformative paradigm by discussing the conceptualization and integration of contemplative pedagogy in a School of Education course, *Mindfulness in Education* and two interdisciplinary courses, *Opening to Other Ways of Knowing and Being* and *Neuropsychology and Meditation*. The aim of this chapter is to provide well-intentioned professors with pedagogical frameworks and practices that will enable the contemplative goals of the course to be more fully reached in service of facilitating transformative learning experiences for students.

As evidenced by the membership of the Association for Contemplative Mind in Higher Education, Mindfulness in Education Network, and participation at the growing number of conferences on contemplative studies such as the Mind and Life International Symposium of Contemplative Studies, we, the authors of this chapter join the multitude of university educators who employ contemplative pedagogy in their practice and praxis. Contemplation, derived from the Greek word *theoria*, refers to a “total devotion to revealing, clarifying and making manifest the nature of reality” (Wallace, 2007, p. 1). Since contemplative pedagogy in higher education can be framed in many ways, in this chapter, we choose to emphasize educational practices which reveal, clarify, and make manifest the nature of the reality of one’s mind, the minds of others, the world, and the relationships among all three.

Contemplative teaching offers a framework of educational vision and practice with the goal of both personal and societal transformation. For too long in education, many faculty have either preserved the status quo (taught as we were taught, learned as our parents and grandparents learned) or simply re-formed our process (often leading to similar outcomes). Transformation offers us a radical path to meet the demands we now face as individuals and society.

At the dawn of the twenty-first century, we find ourselves at a crossroads. Our scientific knowledge of how the world works has never been stronger, but our ability to use it to transform our lives to create greater personal and social harmony remains relatively weak. We can use our technology of the outer world to treat previously incurable diseases, but our mastery of the “technology” of the inner world is so rudimentary that we can barely contain the passions that lead us to destroy the very human life that we, paradoxically, struggle so hard to preserve. We have become the masters of third-person scientific investigation, but we are mere novices in the arts of critical first-person scientific investigation. (Roth, 2006, pp. 1787–88)

Roth expresses the current need to understand, utilize, and develop a first-person perspective of the world, one that synthesizes the technology of the outer, third-person world with the inner, first-person world. We have developed rationales, skills, and techniques to understand the world with external scientific means, but we are only beginning to develop the skills and techniques to explore the inner terrain of our minds and hearts through first-person technology. Palmer, Zajonc, and Scribner (2010) inquire:

How can higher education become a more multidimensional enterprise, one that draws on the full range of human capacities for knowing, teaching, and learning; that bridges the gaps between the disciplines; that forges stronger links between knowing the world and living creatively in it, in solitude and community? (p. 2)

In order to educate our citizens for a global, changing, and interdependent world, we need to attend to the whole person by developing the full range of human capacities including the physical, rational, sensory, and emotional. We cannot reach our full potential if we only focus on the intellect. We need to recognize and develop our understandings of the world and of the self and others through both a distanced third-person perspective, as well as a closer first-person perspective.

Contemplative approaches in education are mirrored in the work of John Dewey, Jean Piaget, Paolo Freire, Daniel Kolb, Ken Wilber, Maria Montessori, Rudolf Steiner, and others who have experiential components as integral to their model. Organizations such as the Center for Contemplative Mind in Society, Garrison Institute, Mind and Life Institute, and the Mindfulness in Education Network have generated research on contemplative education and supported educators integrating contemplation into their professional work in recent years.

While much has been written about the features and kinds of contemplative inquiry (Hart, 2004; Zajonc, 2009; Barbezat & Bush, 2014), little has been written about the pedagogical underpinnings of a contemplative classroom. Too often professors have very little preparation in pedagogy and rely on the pedagogy they experienced as students. As stated, we will outline and demonstrate important pedagogical aspects of an education course on *Mindfulness in Education* designed and taught by Professor Byrnes at Bowdoin College, and two interdisciplinary courses, *Opening to Other Ways of Knowing and Being* and *Neuropsychology and Meditation*, designed and taught by Professor Bassarear at Keene State College. The essential questions explored in the Mindfulness class include: *What distinguishes mindful from mindless education? How do educational models support versus diminish our capacity for mindfulness?* The essential questions explored in the Other Ways of Knowing class include: *What factors have shaped my knowledge of the world? How am I becoming more open to other ways of knowing?*

Our pedagogical decisions are governed by our learning goals for the course, our intentions to build community, foster first-person inquiry, offer differentiated learning activities, and holistically assess student progress and understanding. The pedagogical practices we share here are rooted in stages of contemplative inquiry outlined by Arthur Zajonc (2009). The seven stages of contemplative inquiry are respect, gentleness, intimacy, participation, vulnerability, transformation, and insight. These techniques we describe can be aligned with particular disciplinary content in unique ways and also honor the unity of a contemplative approach to education. Building community may look different in a one hundred-person *Introduction to Psychology* class compared to a sixteen-person *Seminar in Philosophy*, and yet common tools can be employed in either context.

We want to caution our readers that tools or techniques by themselves ignore the conceptual framework of any model in education, and contemplative pedagogy is no exception. There are tools and techniques of contemplative pedagogy, but, as Lee Worley, an educator at the contemplative educational institution Naropa University highlights,

Of course there are techniques that offer support to the contemplative teacher. Listening to the sound of a bell or gong, keeping a clean room. . . . pausing between activities, bowing before and after class, rearranging the desks, and alternating physical with mental activity help facilitate a contemplative message, but contemplative education is not a costume or a theory. These same techniques could benefit any teaching situation, or they could simply be recipe ideas. Without testing them in the fire of the contemplative mind, they remain rather awkward, maybe even weird, and will soon be abandoned by the teacher who isn't doing the necessary "inner work." (Worley, 2005, p. 3)

Our particular choices and styles of contemplative pedagogy have been shaped by our experiences with contemplative practices. We each practice meditation and yoga¹ to cultivate our attention and insight. We have been trained in the Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction program and the Cultivating Emotional Balance program in addition to attending numerous retreats and conferences as contemplative practitioners and educators. Our formal contemplative practices as well as informal practices such as mindful walking, mindful eating, or deep listening serve our ongoing process of development as contemplative practitioners. Other colleagues using contemplative pedagogies have had different experiences and make different choices about what to present and share with students based on their own practices, the discipline/content they are teaching and who their students are and what will best facilitate their learning. What is crucial is that the contemplative teacher has an ongoing commitment to self-discovery and is doing the necessary "inner work" as Worley explains above. "*Testing them (contemplative techniques) in the fire of the contemplative mind*" is a prerequisite and ongoing requirement to employing contemplative pedagogical techniques in a classroom.

In keeping with the concept of individual and societal transformation, the ensuing sections provide an overview of our shared experiences categorized according to our pedagogical intentions emphasizing *building community, exploring first-person inquiry, differentiating learning activities and employing holistic assessment*.

BUILDING COMMUNITY

Acknowledging and supporting an interdependent learning environment through a contemplative pedagogical approach requires an invitation for learners to be active, aware participants in the learning process. Each student has his or her own mindset of the norms and expectations of a college class, so we address these immediately. On the first day of the course, students are invited to help arrange the chairs or desks into a circle as the first community building activity. A circle has no front and back and each person can see everyone else. We use a variety of activities to learn names, e.g., giving your name and home town, your favorite season, something you like about yourself, telling the story of your name—first, middle, last, or nickname, etc. We do this briefly during each class until students begin addressing each other by name during class discussions. After the first few classes, students are invited to suggest what to say as we go around the circle, and they come up with great suggestions—what career would you do if money were not an issue, the farthest place from here that you have journeyed, etc. During these first weeks, we use various pedagogical practices such as walk and talks, think-pair-share, silent conversations, talkers and listeners fishbowl conversations and a Council process.² Building community depends on trusting relationships, so we spend significant time at the beginning of a semester and throughout the semester intentionally building relationships with and among our students. We have found that time spent on building community enables more effective use of class time throughout the semester.

The effective use of time also contributes to community building and is reflected by an intentional and meaningful use of beginnings, middles, and ends of class sessions. This structure facilitates student readiness for learning and student integration of new material with their existing schemas or experiences. We begin and end class with particular practices such as inviting silence or journaling to facilitate smooth transitions for students to “be here now,” to preview the content or skills to be developed and to reflect on their learning. In the middle of class sessions we slowly transition between activities to allow time for concluding thoughts and to emphasize to students that their ideas and thoughts are valued.

In *Mindfulness in Education*, I share on the first day that collectively they are more intelligent and have more experiences than I do as an individual. This does not mean I don’t hold a significant amount of expertise I will share with students, but looking at each other as builders of knowledge is crucial to integrate theory with practice. Within the first four weeks of class, each student presents a five-minute educational autobiography of him or herself as a learner. Students are guided in this process by three questions: *How have you been influenced by your educational experiences? What are some themes or a theme in your educational narrative? Was there a turning point or*

pivotal experience in your education that has led you to where you are today? Using any medium they choose—such as painting, collage, PowerPoint, video, poem, song, essay with images, etc.—they create and share a snapshot of their educational narrative and the impact it has on them as a learner today. These introductions serve as their first formal presentation in the class and facilitate our understanding of who each person is and why they are here. In course evaluations, students have shared the following observations about how this assignment impacts their sense of community.

- I feel that class time is structured as to build a community of learners. Thank you for beginning this semester with educational autobiographies. This assignment gave me the chance to really reflect on my educational journey and the experiences that have shaped me as a learner. I also feel that learning about your background and the backgrounds of my classmates has also been a source of community building for our class.
- I'm appreciative of the autobiographies. Most of the people in the class are seniors, and I had no idea about so many of the experiences they shared. Though I try to be mindful of my relationships, I feel as if we fall into this trap of having superficial relationships where we barely know anything about our friends. I really enjoy what all my classmates have presented because it brings up joys, passions, goals, and it allows us to be vulnerable rather than always trying to be so perfect.
- I really value how comfortable I feel in this class. This is the class where I feel most eager to contribute in small discussions. I really appreciate the autobiographies we did at the beginning as well, because it has allowed me to see past the exterior of people and get to know them in a way I wouldn't otherwise have known. I feel a connection to everyone in our class, even if I haven't actually talked with them yet. When you share intimate parts of your life, you put a lot of trust in the people you share it with.

Contemplative pedagogy emphasizes who is learning and this assignment highlights the importance of who we are in our community of learners. Students appreciate the opportunity to reflect on their educational history and often find the assignment insightful about themselves as learners. Both the similarities and unique experiences expressed in the educational autobiographies enhance classroom community and our understanding of educational systems we have experienced as learners.

In *Other Ways of Knowing and Being*, during the second or third week of class, I tell students that some of my best classes were ones where I learned as much from my peers as I did from the teacher and this is that kind of class. In order for that to happen, all students need to be fully engaged in the

course. For the next class, students reflect on the characteristics of an engaged learner and an engaged classroom in small groups. I elicit and collate their ideas and during the next class we discuss all of the ideas. After considering the ideas, individuals suggest additions, deletions, and edits in italics on an online site. From this document I create a rubric for evaluating their engagement. This document becomes the focal point for our midterm meetings and is completed by the student and myself prior to the meeting when, among other things, we discuss their current grade. We have never been more than a half grade off, and their self-grades are lower than mine more often than above.

Developing a community while holding onto the diversity and individuality of each student is a central concern of contemplative pedagogy. Learning is co-constructed in a community of learners and the value is simultaneously on the community and on the individual learners. Community building is critical and students recognize how this community contributes to their learning process and how unique it is in comparison to their other college classes, where they might not know the names of any other students in the class, much less learn from or with them. Students share that they know every person in our classes, often greet their classmates outside of class, and view the relationships with their peers as central to their learning process.

EXPLORING FIRST-PERSON INQUIRY

Critical first-person scientific investigation or inquiry is one means to foster students' journeys inward through concrete, direct-perception experiences. An exercise in *Other Ways of Knowing* is to ask students to take a walk through campus or sit in the dining hall and just notice their thoughts as they observe other people. I warn them that they will likely notice a lot of judgment and this is actually quite normal. What they notice about their thoughts and the number of thoughts they have amazes and stuns most of the students. Our ensuing class discussion reveals how unaware they were of their thoughts and emotions. The process primes them to bring an interested and non-judgmental attitude to present moment experience.

A similar process occurs in the *Mindfulness in Education* class through labs that meet twice a week for twenty minutes at a time. The labs are organized weekly around one practice and focus on breath (weeks 1–2), body (weeks 3–4), thoughts (weeks 5–6), and emotions (weeks 7–8), for the first half of the semester. The labs offer multiple forms of practices such as breath awareness meditation, yoga, tai chi, contemplative art, dance, mindful speaking and listening, and loving kindness, to give students experience with a toolbox of contemplative practices in community. The regular experience of a practice, and the understanding and commitment to approach each formal

and informal experience as a practice, opens students' understanding of inner and outer worlds in new ways. One student observed, "I have found that simple acts, such as reminding myself to be here now, or taking a few deep breaths can really change the way I feel, act or approach a situation. I must admit that I did not think that such a simple, quick and easy action could have such a large effect." These simple practices are reinforced and also explored through course readings, videos, and discussions. For example, when practicing breath awareness, we read about breath awareness as a practice, the challenges of it and the potential outcomes. Students observe the relevance of the lab practices to their learning. "I love the labs . . . it definitely makes the class for me. I wish we could do more practices in lab. Even when they push my comfort zone, I appreciate them. I also like how we reflect upon labs—that makes them even more rewarding and it is interesting to hear what other people experienced during the practice."

Both classes engage in a twenty-one-day mindful exploration of a behavior, attitude, or contemplative practice. We have experimented with the length of this assignment and find that twenty-one days is doable for students and long enough to get a sense of a daily practice over time. Students keep a daily log of their experience and write a reflection paper at the conclusion of the experience addressing insights they gained, challenges they faced, and how this experience connects with other course materials. Students' reflections reveal the transformative power of critical first-person scientific investigation.

- "I realized that I tend to believe that the outcomes of situations are going to be worse than actually happens."
- "I was surprised that a lot of my opinions about people changed severely. When you dislike or are afraid of something/someone, you need to learn more about it/them. . . . I'm more similar to people around me than I had thought."
- "While in nature, as I study the things I looked at, tasted, heard, felt, and smelled I realized that I was studying myself—how I looked at life, how I looked at myself, and why I thought the way I thought."

Students also discussed the challenges of being disciplined to do one practice every day for twenty-one days, worrying about whether they were doing it "right," doing it for the professor rather than for themselves, or thinking about what they were going to write in their log during their experience rather than being in the present moment. When students share their experiences in small groups or as a whole class, they connect with each others' struggles and successes and realize that while their experience is individual, many of their struggles and insights are similar to others'.

In reflecting on this assignment, we have questioned how to facilitate students' ability to sustain a practice. We have found if the daily logs are optional or not submitted, students' reflection papers can only present a hindsight perspective on their experience. If the logs completed by students are required, students have the data of their first-person inquiry to ground their reflection, which increases the quality of the paper. Holding students accountable, especially when they are trying something new like this assignment, is to their benefit. Making the log "public" in some way to the professor helps students to be disciplined about the practice. The logs are not graded but there is a penalty if they are not submitted.

First-person inquiry experiences such the ones described above or others like observing a plant or a work of art for twenty minutes or bringing mindfulness to their use of technology facilitates students' connections with their mind-body-emotions and heightens their awareness of interconnection. We begin to see similarities where our mind initially categorized difference. We have an embodied sense of how the mind and body influence each other and how my experience in the world influences those around me. Students thus see how first-person inquiry experiences can enhance their understanding of their own mind, the minds of others, and the nature of reality.

DIFFERENTIATING LEARNING ACTIVITIES

Differentiation is the practice of honoring each student's learning needs by accommodating learning activities to increase the engagement of all learners. Differentiation requires knowing what students understand and misunderstand in addition to knowing what is essential in your discipline, so you can effectively connect students with the content. Pedagogical techniques such as controlled choice and opportunities for students to teach or facilitate discussion both within and outside of the class are inclusive of diverse learning needs and foster integration of the inner and outer life. Offering students multiple possibilities to learn and to demonstrate their understanding increases their interest and commitment to an activity. By limiting those choices, we can also create more opportunities for deeper understanding because less time is spent choosing the activity.

In *Other Ways of Knowing and Being*, each student chooses a workshop or event outside of class that represents another way of knowing for him or her. During an experiential unit, students can choose one way of being (play, humor, dance, touch) on which they will do some research and present to the class in an informal panel. In both assignments, students are encouraged to examine new and different ideas critically and openly. Students in the *Mindfulness in Education* class choose an existing poem or write a poem to memorize and recite to the class during the second half of the semester. The

purpose of this learning experience is to practice cultivating a heightened quality of attention while the poem is chosen/written, memorized and recited, and observe the impact of this process on their understanding of the poem. For many students, this level of attention cultivates a sense of connection with their poem. The power to see oneself or one's experience reflected in a poem has the potential to be transformative for students. They recognize how much our quality of attention enhances our experience of external things and builds connection. At the conclusion of the poems, students have a collection of poems that reflect mindfulness in some way and a deeper connection to each other as meaning makers.

Students have opportunities to learn from each other almost every class through small group and large group discussions. Students are encouraged to ask questions of each other and us and to share meaningful understandings of the course materials. In addition, *Mindfulness in Education* students formally are assigned small groups of three to four people based on interests to facilitate a one-hour experience with a particular model of mindfulness education such as MindUP, Mindful Schools, or InnerKids for the rest of the class. The preparation for this teaching experience involves research on the model, interviews with a teacher and student engaged in that model, developing a lesson plan, and three meetings with me to discuss their research and their lesson plan, two weeks and one week before their facilitation as well as a debrief meeting within a week of their facilitation. The experience of facilitating allows students to experiment in a controlled setting with their peers how to utilize contemplative pedagogy as a teacher. Working in a group expands the potential for interpersonal awareness and practice.

We facilitate students' experiments as discussion leaders and teachers in class to heighten their awareness of themselves as learners, similarities and differences they hold with their classmates, and how to think about helping someone else understand something that they know or can do well. As students attempt to be both students and teachers, they often become more inclusive and more divergent in their thinking and learning strategies.

EMPLOYING HOLISTIC ASSESSMENT

While we work in institutions where we measure student learning by grades, we have constructed assessment frameworks that support rather than inhibit the learning process. One primary purpose of assessment is to promote learning of course material; thus, all assessments are opportunities for students to learn and receive feedback on their understanding and performance.

Our assessment practices consist of both formative and summative assessments. Formative assessments serve as feedback for the professor (to glimpse what students understand, misunderstand or are unaware of) as well as feed-

back for students (to recognize what they do and do not understand). Formative assessments typically are completed during a course or a unit of study and may offer opportunities for revision. Summative assessments serve to check student understanding or skill at the completion of a unit or course and in most courses there is little to no feedback given to students. When there is little or no feedback, the assessment loses its formative potential and is simply an externally determined grade.

We design assessments to match our learning objectives for a course. Using an Understanding by Design Framework³ we carefully align assessments with learning objectives and learning activities to scaffold or build student understanding, knowledge, and skill. One assessment we both employ is individual midterm meetings. Students meet with us one-on-one to discuss their progress in the course, what they are learning, their engagement in class and with the content, and goals they have for the second half of the semester. We share feedback with students at this meeting and expect students to guide the discussion, be prepared, and reflect their responses at this point in the semester to the essential questions of the course such as “Why learn mindfully rather than mindlessly?” The midterm serves as a self-assessment followed by a discussion of that assessment and encourages students to reflect on their learning process, where they are challenged and where they could challenge themselves.

At multiple points in the semester we informally solicit student feedback on the course and their learning process. Through exit cards at the end of a class, we ask students to respond anonymously to prompts that range from assessing student understanding of content (e.g., what were the three major points in the reading?); gauging student interest (e.g., what aspects of this class are you most/least excited about?); identifying issues (e.g., describe one question you have about ideas discussed in class); or eliciting student perceptions (e.g., how much progress have you made on the research paper? How was today’s class?). We also do course evaluations at one or two points during the course so we can use the feedback throughout the course, rather than just an end-of-course evaluation that cannot be used to meaningfully affect those learners. Questions during a course evaluation include: Describe the essential understandings you have about the course at this point. What do you most appreciate about the class? What is the least rewarding aspect of this class for you? What can you do to improve your understanding and appreciate of this class? What can you do to help the class be a better class for you and everyone else? (adapted from Sid Brown, 2008). During a class session, we will often pause for a quick “fist to five survey” on a question such as, “How interesting was the reading for today?” A fist is zero, or not at all, and a five is “it changed my world.” Asking students to reflect on their learning and on the particular content signals the importance of them as

active, engaged learners who are making meaning from this educational experience.

I use a protocol when I invite a student to my office who appears to be struggling in the *Other Ways of Knowing* course. I share with the student: “I see more potential than your behavior would indicate. There are many possible factors that might be contributing to low performance.” I name some possibilities such as personal, academic, social, or health issues and explain support offices/persons at the college for each. I find that the student usually relaxes and then starts talking, almost like they had been given truth serum, but actually it was merely permission to be human. A key element to the success of this practice is describing the behavior without blaming or judging the student. At the same time, I am clear in my communication about specific behaviors that are acceptable and/or unacceptable, and the reasonable consequence for both. All of this requires a commitment to my relationship with the student. Mistakes are a part of the learning process and some mistakes have larger consequences than others, but both the mistakes and the consequences can be discussed without being judging, harsh, or moralizing. Rumi wrote, “Out beyond ideas of wrongdoing and rightdoing, there is a field. I’ll meet you there” (Barks, p. 36). We do attempt to meet our students and ourselves there in that field.

With the development of community and trust, not all meaningful assessment needs to come from the instructor. For example, Arnold, a highly intelligent, disciplined student who has been successful in school, found the practices during our mindfulness lab, especially breath awareness, difficult, and at one point in the semester decided that mindfulness was not for him. Later, he was in a dyad conversation with a peer who expanded his perspective by offering a short addendum to his phrase; “It’s not for me, *right now*.” She gave him permission to struggle and to take a view that this might not be a permanent trait but rather a current state. For someone who habitually “got” things right away, this was a new perspective and was a transformative experience for Arnold. He received and wrestled with the feedback from a peer on his learning process.

BECOMING CONTEMPLATIVE KNOWERS

Similar to educator Maria Lichtmann (2005), we desire to share the beauty, goodness, and truth at the heart of the educational process with our students and facilitate their growth as contemplative knowers. We want to offer them the best and most useful of what we have experienced and understand about learning and teaching; contemplative pedagogy is the practice by which we do this. Contemplative pedagogy integrates theory and practice in our classrooms in ways that increase the learning potential of individuals as well as

the learning community. We have shared multiple pedagogical practices we employ in our courses with undergraduate students to meet our intentions of: building community, fostering first-person inquiry, offering differentiated learning activities, and holistically assessing student progress and understanding. We utilize these pedagogical tools in our classrooms because the practices facilitate our students' deeper understanding of themselves, others, the world, and specifically the material they study in our classes. Students practice cultivating their inner resources of attention and insight and apply those skills and understandings to the content of the course and often to their lives. We have and continue to struggle to discern pedagogical strategies that are just right instead of too much or too little, and when and how to prepare students for particular contemplative practices. An outcome of our own personal contemplative practices in our professional lives is an intentional awareness of space, time, and the teaching presence cultivated through an embodied understanding of the relationships between professor, student, and content in the learning process.

One year in *Other Ways of Knowing and Being* I asked the students to read Arthur Zajonc's seven stages of contemplative inquiry and comment: "Are these important? Do you see these embodied in the classroom? Missing? Would you add to his list? Students observed that *Respect* involves trust of self, other students, and the teacher; *Gentleness* involves letting go and surrender; *Intimacy* involves passion and love and connects self, other students, the content, and the teacher; *Participation* involves engagement with others and having a role in what happens in the class; *Vulnerability* involves learning to value not knowing instead of always having to be certain, developing an open mind, and letting go of assumptions. *Transformation* and *Insight* were not elaborated. We feel that students being able to see and make sense of these stages is directly connected to the four aspects described in this paper: community, first-person inquiry, differentiation, and holistic assessment.

As educators we engage in these stages of contemplative inquiry especially in our work with students. Students who are struggling, who are overwhelmed by reality when they see it, or who are avoiding connecting theory practice come to our office hours, ask us to a meal or talk to us after class. We practice respect, gentleness, intimacy, participation, and vulnerability in these and all interactions. These seven stages facilitate our growth and our students' growth toward being contemplative knowers. Parker Palmer, Arthur Zajonc, and Megan Scribner close their 2010 book, *The Heart of Higher Education*, by reminding us,

Education is a vital, demanding and precious undertaking, and much depends on how well it is done. If it is true to the human being, education must reflect our nature in all its subtlety and complexity. Every human faculty must be

taken seriously, including the intellect, emotions, and our capacity for relational, contemplative, and bodily knowing. An integrative education is one that offers curricula and pedagogies that employ and deploy all these faculties, delights in their interactions, and is spacious enough to allow for their creative conflict. . . . Educate our students as whole people, and they will bring all of who they are to the demands of being human in private and public life. The present and future well-being of humankind asks nothing less of us. (pp. 152–53)

NOTES

1. For a list of practices, see the Tree of Contemplative Practices at <http://contemplative-mind.org>.
2. For a description of these practices, see Appendix A: Learning Activities to Build Community.
3. For more information see Wiggins and McTighe (2005). *Understanding by Design* Alexandria, VA: ASCD.

APPENDIX A: LEARNING ACTIVITIES TO BUILD COMMUNITY

Students are asked to generate *agreements* in small groups that will facilitate our ability to communicate with each other as learners. They can consider agreements whether explicit or not in other classes that have been effective in facilitating dialogue and sustaining engaged inquiry in theories and practices. With a list of suggestions, I choose as the professor the two to four agreements that collectively address the ideas proposed in short, simple statements that are easily remembered. One year the three class agreements were: *Seek to understand before you seek to be understood*, *Be responsible for the energy you bring to the space*, and *Challenge yourself to transform*. Another year they were: *Be present and maintain an open mind*, *Practice humility*, and *Cultivate connection through community*. The involvement of students in this process serves as a reflective tool on the attributes that contribute to a positive, meaningful learning community.

The *talkers and listeners fishbowl conversations* also highlight the strengths and challenges of preferring to speak or to listen as a way to learn and how as a community we can appreciate and harness the strengths of both and challenge ourselves as individuals to cultivate both skills.

Walk and talks involve pairs of students going for a walk around campus while discussing a particular question, reading, or concept for ten to twenty minutes. The movement of walking and the orientation to being side-by-side rather than face-to face can open interesting possibilities for discussion.

Think-pair-share involves time for individual reflection either in writing or in a person's head followed by moving into pairs randomly with students, then sharing what insights or questions each generated during the reflection.

This learning activity allows students to be both listeners and talkers and to actively engage with a text or question.

Silent conversations can occur on white or blackboards, through a computer program like Google Docs, or on multiple pieces of large paper and typically last about fifteen to twenty minutes. I pose a question or a controversial statement and students can write their responses, other questions, and dialogue purely through writing that is visible to the whole community. If the group is larger than ten students, I will offer a couple of questions or statements to allow more students to write at the same time.

Council is a process of dialogue that has been used for centuries in many indigenous traditions to develop deeper understanding of the perspectives of others, even perspectives that appear to be in conflict. The guidelines (which are seen as intentions or invitations as opposed to rules) are to speak from the heart, listen from the heart, to speak spontaneously and be brief. Students pass a “talking stick,” which can be any object, and address a particular question such as “What does this quote or point [from a reading] bring up in you?” “What did you get from the activity that we did,” or “What brings you joy?” The talking stick encourages deep listening, an appreciation for individual differences and nurtures connections.

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Chapter Four

Living Collaborative Leadership

Cultivating a Mindful Approach

Sabre Cherkowski, Kelly Hanson, and Jennifer Kelly

As the discussion in this volume moves away from evidence-based discourses and mindfulness-informed curricula, a beautiful story that helps us reflect on the promise and potential of mindful leadership is “The Cracked Water Pot.” In this story, a water bearer is responsible for carrying two pots of water to his master’s house each day. Over time, one of the pots becomes depressed and frustrated because of a leak that results in only half the water being delivered from his pot. The pot worries and frets over this shortcoming and eventually he apologizes to the water bearer for his terrible flaw. The water bearer takes a compassionate stance and asks the despondent pot to notice the beautiful flowers blooming along the path to the master’s house. Noticing that the pot is still dispirited, the water bearer asks him to notice that there are flowers blooming only on his side of the path. He explains that he noticed the pot’s crack and planted seeds on that side of the path. From the leaking water, beautiful flowers grew that he was able to offer to his master at each visit. From this experience, the pot was now able to notice his leak as a gift, a talent even, and was able to be proud and engage again in his work.

From this story, we can imagine that the water bearer might have been inspired by a higher purpose in his leadership, beyond completing the task of delivering water, to focusing on beauty, compassion, and kindness for others as part of what it means to be a leader. We see that this focus on developing positive human capacities in others can be understood as a mindful approach to leadership. Moving beyond the responsibility for ensuring that others are working toward task-completion, and centering on the process of cultivating relationships and encouraging positive human capacity development is one aspect of a mindful approach to leadership.

From this story we also notice a second aspect—that even when the water bearer had created conditions which ensured success of the unique characteristics of the cracked pot, the cracked pot could not see his own development and his interior condition was fueled by self-doubt and disappointment. It was not until, in a moment of vulnerability, the cracked pot revealed his inner turmoil and the pot carrier revealed his plan was there, opening the space for new meaning making. Transformation occurred through connecting, through a dialogue which revealed multiple perspectives and allowed a new story to emerge. Collective storytelling is another aspect of a mindful approach to leadership, where the higher goal is to deepen community (Born, 2014). Therefore, we see a mindful approach to leadership as two-fold. First, it calls on capacities for becoming aware of the strength of others, and second, mindful leadership requires actively engaging in collective meaning-making and community-building.

To cultivate the strengths of others and to deepen community through collaboration, mindful leaders start with generating awareness and appreciation of self. Many conceptions of mindful leadership entail a deep and ongoing knowledge of self gained through contemplative practices such as meditation, journaling, and deep listening (Gonzalez, 2012; Marturano, 2014, Jaworski, 2011, Scharmer, 2009). We assume that engaging in self work requires this ongoing personal development to inquiring into authenticity, compassion, curiosity, and commitment at the level of self (Cherkowski, 2014a). Throughout this chapter, we describe experiences and understandings of mindful leadership from a stance of self-awareness as a learning journey, which ultimately extends to the larger purpose of connecting with others on a common higher ground, or toward a higher purpose at work. We call this learning journey, from self to community, a mindful approach to leadership, and it is describing this learning journey that is the focus of our chapter.

To co-write this chapter, the three of us reflected on our experiences with mindful leadership from our different experiences and roles. This combining of perspectives and experiences broadened and deepened our conception of a mindful approach to leadership. We offered our self-perspectives to each other and to the reader, and in doing so we moved from individual reflection to creating a culture of inquiry, a fluid way of coming to share knowledge through continual questioning and dialogue. As we will describe in a later section of this chapter, we have made connections between our learning journey as co-writers and living educational theory (Delong, 2013; Whitehead, 2008). This perspective encourages inquiry into practice by uncovering and learning from the educational influences that shape our thinking and behavior. This personal reflection is deepened and enriched as we join with others to seek feedback, critique, and clarity, ultimately cultivating a culture of inquiry (Delong, 2013). Our exploration of mindful leadership in this

chapter involves explaining the educational influences that have impacted our learning, and negotiating this learning as part of a collaborative writing process. We offer that sharing our knowledge in this way can highlight the collaborative, generative, and creative nature of a mindful approach to leadership. As we collaborated to develop the writing of this chapter, we wrestled with how to name and label our understandings. We decided that our use of a mindful approach to leadership provides a shift in how mindful leadership has often been taken up in the research literature, and gives a sufficiently broad space for capturing many more ways of experiencing this learning journey.

We have organized this chapter in three sections, each with its own voice and description of experiences that explain various perspectives on mindfulness, all with the larger purpose of establishing our broader conception of what we understand as a mindful approach to leadership. In each of the sections, we offer examples from the research literature and provide stories from our own experiences in our work, again, with the underlying belief that exploring our stories, as educational leaders, is an important reflective practice that has the potential for transformational change and deepening community. Kelly is a middle-school Humanities teacher and doctoral student. We begin with her overview of research on mindfulness from an Eastern perspective, and her own practice of mindfulness using recent examples from her self-study of becoming a more socially just teacher. Jen is a literacy resource teacher and a doctoral student. She provides a description of mindfulness from a more Western perspective, and uses examples from her work as an educational leader in her school district to illuminate how the mindfulness theories can inform and inspire our work as educational leaders. Finally, Sabre is a faculty member in Education, and is the doctoral supervisor for both Jen and Kelly. She describes her research on flourishing in schools (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013a, 2013b, 2013c, 2014), a positive, strengths-based, appreciative model of school improvement with a focus on human capacity development. A central question of Sabre's flourishing research is: What if learning how to thrive, and helping others to do the same, is the central work of teaching and learning (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013b)? This question is an overarching theme in this chapter and is also reflected in the conclusion. We conclude the chapter with a reflection on the process of understanding our notion of a mindful approach to leadership through a living theory perspective (DeLong, 2013; Whitehead, 1989, 2008), and a discussion of how we, as researchers and writers, were empowered by this perspective on knowledge and methodology that embraces an embodied awareness of the self and a valuing of personal knowledge-building within a social context.

MINDFULNESS IN SCHOOLS: AN EASTERN PERSPECTIVE

Much of the current writing and research on mindful leadership is taken up from an Eastern philosophical perspective of mindfulness through meditation linked with increased social-emotional learning and regulation. For example, Janice Marturano (2014) is a leading expert in mindful leadership who has established a model of mindful leadership based on mindfulness practices for attending in the present so as to unleash creativity, compassion, through clarity, and focus. Through meditation and practices designed to improve self-awareness, mindful leaders gain important insights into their personal strengths and talents, their ability to recognize and regulate their emotions in response to stressful situations, and an increasing ability to tap into a sense of peace and presence in the moment-to-moment interactions at work.

The Leader Within:

Kelly's Reflections as a Middle-School Teacher

My mindful practice is a daily work in progress that started ten years into my teaching practice when I began a two-year self-study as part of my Master of Education research. My use of the term “mindfulness” reflects an Eastern tradition wherein mindfulness could be described as the continuous practice of connecting with life deeply, yet with a detachment from habitual thoughts and fears, in every moment (Hahn, 2009). My experience was an unexpected awakening into the world of mindfulness. My initial goal was to improve my practice as a social justice teacher, and I chose to study my self because I wanted to make sure that my actions in my teaching were aligned with my social justice values. Through my approach to this goal I experienced a shift; I started to connect my self as an educator to my highest self-potential. This shift was a result of using self-study as a way to engage with my personal learning process to identify my goals and to act with greater alignment with those intentions. Self-study is an inquiry into one's own actions in order to achieve a deepened consciousness of self that extends beyond habits and traditions (Samaras & Freese, 2009). My self-study included a daily journaling practice and sharing my reflections with others as a way to reframe and relearn about myself. Once I learned to be self-compassionate within this process I began to develop a quality of consciousness that was flexible, receptive, and nonjudgmental toward my current experience.

Thus, it was a relatively new educational research methodology, self-study, which connected me to the ancient practice of mindfulness and then to leadership. Self-study provided me the opportunity to be reflective as I shifted my attention to my inner landscape through a growing collection of journal entries. The impact of a reflective mindset transferred beyond the pages of my journal and the quality of my self-awareness became more

anchored in the present moment in other aspects my life, in my classroom and beyond. Further, as my research developed I incorporated other contemplative practices into my life as a teacher, such as breathing, cultivating physical awareness, and listening deeply.

My mindful practice awakened a new capacity within me, qualities I began to identify as leadership. My learning was self-directed, and insights into self led to collaboratively developed insights into human capacity. My self-study included the influence of eastern Buddhist leaders and their ideas, such as nonviolent conflict transformation, truthfulness, and detachment from wants and desires, as well as the influence of my colleagues, fellow educational researchers, and mentors. These trusted sources became my learning community and created a lens to know, and relearn, self. Through self-study, I offered the following questions to my community: Who is my true self and what is my work? The following two sections are reflections on my collective sense-making around these questions and how they impacted my sense of leadership.

Highest Possible Self

Offering self, my stories, and my ways of thinking to my community as a source of learning has become a ceaseless and constantly evolving exploration. Awareness of self can be facilitated by a practice of suspension, redirection, and letting go (Depraz, Varela, & Vermersch, 2003). Suspension is about suspending habitual ways of thinking by first observing them. Redirection refers to directing attention from the exterior world to the interior world of self, and to let go is to develop and open new connections and intentions. In my experiences, through suspending, redirection, and letting go, I began to connect to a sense of wonder and curiosity as if seeing myself and my profession for the first time. I saw my beliefs and passions clearly, and saw how ego, fear, shame, and uncertainty created contradictions and barriers to actualizing those beliefs.

For me, self-awareness was a means to clarify my call to social justice. I realized that I had been telling myself stories that were distracting me from my goals of social justice. I also realized that we can create communities to challenge and relearn these stories, and not just by creating a new story but by creating distance between self and story. Distance between self and story means that we hold our beliefs and ideas lightly, with flexibility and open-mindedness. To me, this insight is integral to living in a pluralistic society. Though the process of detaching from my dominant stories in favor of considering multiple perspectives, I gained greater insights into justice. In other words, the way to do is to be (Heider & Lao-tzu, 1986). As I developed self-awareness, I began to embody a higher self; I was living my own life with

more authenticity. I believe this is living leadership. Leading by being can also be referred to as presence.

Being Leadership: Presence

My early writing on collaboration during my self-study research depicted how I tended to see collaboration: as a task to get things done; time-consuming; threatening, when I felt vulnerable if I did not have all the answers; or as a frustration when needing to come to consensus. Through mindful reflection I first identified these frustrations and then began to wonder if I was creating a barrier between myself and others based these feelings and what would happen if I suspended these emotions. I started to reflect on times when my work with others was incredibly valuable. I noticed in those times how creative and generative the outcomes were. In this noticing I became at greater peace when working with others.

Presence, or being open and in tune with the present moment, increases an individual's ability to offer one's self to others. Jaworski (2011) uses Greenleaf's (2008) conceptualization of servant leadership to describe a leadership of presence. The term servant leadership was harvested from the story "Journey to the East" (Hesse, 1956 as cited in Jaworski, 2011), wherein a band of men set off looking for enlightenment. Along the way they are kept entertained by their servant, Leo, who, as well as doing menial tasks, maintains group morale with his spirit, presence, and song. Unfortunately, along the journey Leo disappears. With Leo gone, the whole group loses its way. It is not until years of wandering pass that the narrator, one of the original band of men, is reconnected to Leo and he is then able to complete his journey. Jaworski (2011) writes, "Leo . . . was actually the head of the order, its guiding spirit, a great and noble leader. Leo by the quality of the inner life that was expressed by his presence, had served to lift the group up and make their journey possible" (p. 59). In this way, self-aware, mindful leaders develop the capacity in others through the fruits of their own inner well-being.

To develop self-awareness I offered myself wholeheartedly to my profession and our community, and this role-modeling became an invitation to others to do the same. In my research, my servant approach to leadership led others to also act from a place of authenticity. In my research, I shared my journal entries with a community of learners. As a result of these interactions my ideas about self shifted and evolved. The most significant shift was the realization that we are dependent upon each other to move beyond our own barriers. Transformative learning does not emerge in isolation; the discovery of our highest possible self is also the discovery of the highest possible self of others and is a building block toward deepening community.

MINDFULNESS FROM A WESTERN PERSPECTIVE

Situated in the Present:

Jen's Reflections on Mindfulness in Schools

Individual mindfulness requires flexibility, openness, and an ability to adapt behavior to different situations based on clear cognitive appraisal. Developing mindfulness in this way can lead to an ability to create new cognitive categories for information in response to new and unfamiliar situations. Increasing mindfulness can lead to a desire to seek out new experiences in order to consider multiple perspectives and challenge world views, as a way of avoiding the limited thinking that often comes from considering singular perspective. In this way, curiosity and wonder drive us to continue exploring unknown territory. Consider Martusewicz's (1997) description of the wonder and curious nature apparent in many children:

I know that little girl's passion for questions. The pleasure of the questions. Warm sun on her back. Looking at grass. "Why do I see green? Does my mother see the same green, or is her green blue, like my sky? Does this sky touch me?" Something moves her. There's a limit here; she knows she can't know the answers, and yet . . . something else. I feel her desire to share these questions, for someone else to feel the intensity, the wonder of it all. And perhaps to be touched by another's wonder too, a desire for connection to the world and to the other, through this passion to know.

She runs into the kitchen. She runs in there with her questions. "Mom! Could your green be my blue? What is the sky?" She gives them to her. She wants her to love them, too, to love her questions. At four she knows that love is in those questions, a particular kind of love. It's impossible that her mother should not know this, too. But the woman does not turn; she remains at the sink. (p. 97)

In this scene, Martusewicz highlights the loss of wonder that can happen when adults become complacent through years of ignoring their curiosity for new learning and focusing instead on the drudge of day-to-day life. In contrast, mindfulness is paying attention to questions, and an awareness of the possibility of the multiplicity of answers and questions. This attunement to multiple realities, experiences, and expectations opens the space to explore without defined limitations of absolutes, which can act as a boundary to mindfulness.

Mindfulness can be defined differently depending on one's perspective and theoretical context. While a more Eastern perspective on mindfulness focuses on meditation and other contemplative practices to attain a level of internal stillness from which clarity of mind and heart can be achieved, a more Western perspective of mindfulness can be broadly defined as a process

of actively observing new things and making decisions based on attentiveness (Haas & Langer, 2014) by continually seeking disconfirming evidence from previous assumptions and experience (Hoy, Gage, & Tarter, 2006).

Mindful Adult Learning

This reflective process of re-defining knowledge reflects the open-minded stance described in Western perspectives on mindfulness. Both adult learning theory (Mezirow, 2000) and mindfulness theory (Langer, 1989) can inform how we think about professional learning experiences for teachers. The connection between adult learning theory and mindfulness can create cultural shifts in schools when educational leaders are cognizant of creating environments conducive to mindful learning. Learning signifies change in mindset, ideas, perceptions or knowledge and continually assessing relevance in order to make an interpretation and connect to or adapt previously-held beliefs. Adult learning theory focuses on “the process of using a prior interpretation to construe a new or revised interpretation of the meaning of one’s experience as a guide to future action” (Mezirow, 2000, p. 5). The desire to become more liberated, socially responsible, and autonomous learners drives adults to continue the learning journey guided by continuous scrutiny of expectations based on new experiences (Hoy et al., 2006). For example, personal professional learning for teachers is different depending on the needs of each individual teacher and their theoretical perspective on the acquisition of knowledge and the reason for continuous learning. Finding ways to experience their learning in a relevant and meaningful way can significantly alter their sense of self in some way. Both adult learning theory and mindfulness prompt us to think about how we know, rather than what we know.

CONNECTING MINDFUL LEARNING TO MINDFUL LEADING

In terms of how teachers learn, mindfulness theory offers four distinct characteristics that reflect a similar understanding of the particular needs of adults as learners. Thinking about professional development in schools, as we consider teacher professional learning from an adult learning theory perspective we notice how mindfulness theory also informs how we understand adult learning in schools. In this section, I describe four specific characteristics of mindfulness theory as related to adult learning: presence, self-directed learning, novelty, and different perspectives.

Presence: The Human Experience

Mindfulness can be described as being present and in the moment (Rodgers & Raider-Roth, 2006; Langer, 1989; Newmark, Krahne, & Seaton, 2013). From this state of presence, an awareness of the interconnectedness of mental, emotional, and physical states improves considered and thoughtful decision-making processes. Learning about the self and feeling a freedom to take risks in learning are further benefits of learning that can emerge from a mindful state of presence (Rodgers & Raider-Roth, 2006). In terms of educational leaders, noticing and attending to the various needs of teachers as learners is becoming an important aspect of leadership (Hargreaves & Fullan, 2013). Mindfulness can shape leadership practices for greater presence and help leaders to let go of pre-conceived expectations they have of others and allow for more genuine responses to each teacher as an individual. Authentically developing and nurturing mindfulness in a school environment is a positive way to improve teacher social-emotional well-being (Jennings & Greenberg, 2009).

Self-Directed Learning: Designing Your Own Path

By recognizing the impact of self-directed learning versus moving along a pre-determined path that has been set out for teachers can impact the relevance and meaning connecting to the learning (Langer, 1989). A mindful educational leader models self-directed learning, curiosity, and open-mindedness and encourages others to be mindful in their own learning. Findings ways to connect with teachers and build relationships to facilitate a greater sense of ownership for professional learning can shift a culture of learning toward inquiry and possibility (Cherkowski, 2014b). As highlighted in adult learning theory, sharing experiences about learning in a safe, comfortable environment, may elicit openness to questions and inquiry among adult learners (Cranton, 2006).

Novelty: Fulfilling Your Curiosity

In her research on mindfulness, Langer (1989) argues that novelty needs to be present for learning to take place. Interestingly, novelty can be focused on through the lens of flourishing. Teachers and leaders can promote opportunities to notice how passion and intrigue are presenting themselves in novel ways in their classrooms or in the school environment. Teachers should be encouraged to play with ideas, to take risks, to experiment in the classroom, which may lead to a sense of novelty and ignite passion in the classroom (Hoy et al., 2006). By focusing on experiences which teachers are genuinely concerned about and trying to gain different perspectives on, professional development experiences may actually inspire novelty and mindfulness

through the nature of thoughtful discussions among colleagues and school leaders.

Different Perspectives: Leading and Learning From Others

Collegial conversations can be another means of facilitating openness to new ideas. For example, engaging in conversations with teachers about the intent of professional learning can be a good opportunity for school leaders to establish a more open environment for talking about the needs, challenges, and benefits of professional learning and can provide a more open forum for different perspectives on these ideas. Mindful educational leaders accept that teachers need to be able to express their different perspectives about professional learning, and to challenge ideas that do not necessarily make sense to their way of thinking. Mindful educational leaders recognize the value of sharing practices with colleagues and establish structures, spaces that honour and value reflective practice as part of the work of teaching and that can lead to establishing a more engaged culture of professional learning in the school.

What Mindful Leadership Can Look Like in Schools

School is an institution that can look like a factory run by a manager, or it can look like a place that is continually fostering curiosity in students, teachers, and school leaders. The term “school culture” generally refers to the relationships, beliefs, and attitudes that shape and influence every aspect of how a school functions. Establishing and sustaining school culture that is adaptable to the complexity of day-to-day school life is an essential aspect of school leadership (Louis & Wahlstrom, 2011). These authors suggest that culture can affect motivation of teachers as well as their ability to solve conflicts, share innovative ideas and reflect on their own learning. By entrenching mindfulness into the culture of a school, it may lead to reflective practice and a thoughtful approach to novel learning.

My own experience as a district literacy leader has highlighted the potential transformational possibilities of embracing teacher learning from the perspectives of adult learning theory and mindfulness theory. Through a literacy project designed to elicit a sense of inquiry into professional learning for improving literacy instruction, I have seen a school culture shift from an institution where teachers used their professional learning time to organize their own classroom, to a place that shifted to focus on wonderment and curiosity in collective learning. Teachers were engaged in small learning communities to learn how to develop collegial relationships that would enable dialogue about teaching practices and the resulting student learning. These meetings evolved into safe and caring communities where teachers felt free to share their challenges, concerns, celebrations, and successes. Estab-

lishing the structures and processes for being present with each other, to connect in a more substantial way with each other, and to learn about each other as colleagues, and eventually, as friends, created relationships of support and care that have influenced how these teachers go about their work of teaching and learning. There is now constant conversation among teachers about what their students are doing and about what they are going to try next. The school leader is rarely in her office but instead is in classrooms, sitting on the floor with students—reading, listening, or just being present. I began asking questions to discover how the transformation in this school culture occurred—but there is no one easy answer. We do know that it started when professional learning changed for the teachers. They were given the freedom to explore their curiosity with the support of time and resources from the school leader. Teachers continue to develop their own learning journey. They maintain their relationships of presence, care, curiosity, and interdependence and are becoming a model for other teachers about how to mindfully engage in professional learning as interested, invested, and motivated adult learners.

LEADERFUL MINDSETS: SABRE'S REFLECTIONS ON FLOURISHING

With my colleagues, I have been exploring ways of understanding the experience of teaching, leading, and learning from a positive, human capacity development perspective. We have been researching flourishing in schools (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013a, 2013b, 2013c, 2014a, 2014b), as a way of shifting the attention of school improvement toward what is going well and giving vitality to the work of teaching and learning in schools. We used findings from research in positive psychology and positive organizational scholarship to establish an alternative approach to research on school improvement, one that pays attention from a strengths-based, appreciative, human capacity development perspective. We have noticed the shift in energy and awareness that can occur with a shift in attention toward that which makes us feel more alive in our work as teachers and school leaders. We center our research on the belief that with focused and sustained attention to the human capabilities of those within the school, schools can become positive institutions and can become the “vehicles for bringing more humanity, courage, wisdom, love and value into the world” (Cooperrider, n.d.). In our research we explore the impact on learning communities in schools when teachers and other school leaders highlight, encourage, and foster professional virtues of compassion, trust, and hope at work (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013a, 2013b), and where the values of purpose, passion, and play are emphasized and lived out in schools (Cherkowski & Walker, 2014b). As part of our conceptualizing of flourishing in schools, we have noted that an inten-

tional focus and attention on noticing, nurturing, and sustaining a mindset that fosters an openness of mind, heart, and spirit to the joys, mysteries, and unlimited abundance, among other capacities, can be an important aspect of cultivating flourishing in self and others at school. We call this mindset a *leaderful* one and suggest that this is characterized by an understanding of the power of the emergent and shared nature of leadership, that anyone at any time can activate their agency as a leader in their own work as they tap into higher purposes and frame their work within goals that transcend individuals and connect to a larger collective (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013b). In our flourishing model, the Leaderful Mindset domain reflects the understanding that sustainable school improvement is more attainable when many share the challenges and the benefits of shaping and informing a positive school culture. As well, this domain highlights the potential within each of us to shift how we frame our work to be able to engage from a place of higher purpose with a desire to connect with others at work in a more meaningful, authentic, and present way.

As I have described (Cherkowski, 2014a), attending to relationships and connecting to a higher collective purpose is an important part of leading organizations, and we have suggested that more research is needed to better understand how leaders create the space for individuals and groups to connect, first to their own self and then to each other, through attending to a higher purpose or transcending set of values. Indeed, Margaret Wheatley (2005) described her belief that “in the future, those organizations who will succeed are those that evoke our greatest human capacities, our need to be in good relationships, and our desire to contribute to something beyond ourselves” (p. 124). Similarly, in their writing about positive leadership, Quinn and Thakor (2014) describe how “when a leader commits to a higher purpose, and inspires others to follow, the principal-agent problem is altered. Employees who embrace the higher purpose are transformed: they derive positive value from their effort and act more like principals” (p. 102). In other words, paying attention to a higher purpose at work can inspire others to seek to feel transformed themselves and to engage more readily as a leader in their own work. In schools, this could translate to mean that as Leaderful Mindsets are cultivated through attention to a higher purpose in connection with others at work, teachers and formal school leaders have the opportunity to contribute to developing professional capacity across the system.

This idea of intentionally seeking to connect with others at work on a common ground of higher purpose resonates with the ideas presented earlier about mindful leadership, where gaining clarity and focus through meditative practices about intentions, values, beliefs align with actions leading to improved personal and relational outcomes at work. A Leaderful Mindset highlights the potential of using our attention to shift the focus of our awareness, and that the focus of attention often starts with an inward reflection on self.

To think about ways of eliciting and amplifying this awareness of the capability within each of us to engage in purposeful ways as a leader in our own work, we have developed a series of questions that serve to notice, nurture, and sustain Leaderful Mindsets in schools (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013c). In his research in business settings, Lencioni (2012) aimed to understand why it was that some work settings contributed to miserable work in the hopes of understanding how to alleviate this misery at work. He found that three signs of a miserable job could be identified by a prevalence of anonymity, inability to see contributions to the organization, and a lack of feedback in the workplace. We noticed that re-framing these questions provided a positive entry into understanding how individuals take ownership of their own work and their contributions to the larger organization. We adapted and extended these questions from a positive organizational research perspective toward an appreciative perspective on Leaderful Mindsets, the recognition that individuals can have agency for thriving in their work, and in so doing can contribute to the thriving of others. As will be described below, the questions apply to noticing, nurturing, and sustaining personal leadership in the “Am I” form of the question. We see how shifting the questions to a “Do I” form enables a shift in thinking toward collective leadership. The four questions for noticing, nurturing, and sustaining Leaderful Mindsets are:

1. Am I seen? Do I see others?
2. Am I learning and growing? Do I help others to learn and grow?
3. Am I contributing my strengths? Do I help other to contribute their strengths?
4. Am I seeking feedback? Do I give feedback?

Asking the first question provides insights into how we honor our true self through our work, our *authenticity* at work. As part of what it means to present our true self through work, we must come to understand and examine our personal vision, values, and beliefs, and notice how these align with our actions at work as well as with the larger goals and visions of the school within which we work. The second question urges us to examine our personal professional growth through a reflection on our state of ongoing learning and growth at work, our professional *curiosity*. Further reflection on this question engages observations about how we ensure spaces and resources for ongoing learning at work. The third question elicits reflection on how we contribute our strengths toward the betterment of the learning community, a *commitment* to ongoing personal professional development. This question requires a knowledge of self in terms of strengths, gifts, and talents that can be offered toward the betterment of my learning community. This question reflects the appreciative approach to positive organizational research. As this question moves from thinking about individual to collective agency, ideas

about shared and service-oriented leadership, as well as ideas about seeking a diversity of perspective and contributions are evoked. Finally, the fourth question focuses attention on personal and collective accountability for engaging wholeheartedly at work with the intention of seeking a higher purpose toward deeper meaning in our work. This can be understood as professional *courage*. This final question asks us to reflect on how well we are seeking out feedback from others on our process of engaging with a Leaderful Mindset.

Ongoing reflection on these questions is characterized by a focus on authenticity, curiosity, a commitment to personal professional development, and courage to undertake the personal and collective reflection necessary for continuous improvement. A mindful approach to asking these questions urges us to suspend judgment and to gain clarity and focus through attention to presence in the reflective process. Similar to how the water bearer created an opportunity for the leaky pot to notice his strengths and appreciate his contributions to the process of water delivery, we assume that the cumulative effect of asking and answering these questions as part of a mindful approach to leadership can develop Leaderful Mindsets and contribute to increasing personal and collective flourishing in schools.

UNDERSTANDING OUR LEARNING JOURNEY THROUGH LIVING EDUCATIONAL THEORY

We see how the process of engaging in reflective inquiry for insights on our individual experiences within the social contexts of our work and lives can be understood as a mindful approach to leadership. In our writing, our research, and our practice, we have been exploring alternate ways of knowing how we come to learn about ourselves in our work as a way of gaining a deeper awareness of how we are connecting with and contributing to a larger purpose with others in our work, seeking a common higher ground of purpose. Jack Whitehead's notion of *living educational theory* (1989, 2008) supports these ideas of coming to know the various "educational influences of individuals in their own learning, in the learning of others and in the learning of the social formations in which we live and work" (p. 105) as a primary source of knowledge about teaching, learning, living, and contributing to growing more humanity in our work and life. He argues that building this knowledge requires a valuation of forms of theory and knowledge that have generally been devalued by those who claimed the primacy of traditional disciplines of theory, such as philosophy, psychology, educational history, and others, as both legitimized sources of knowledge and perspectives from which to carry out education research (Whitehead, 2008). He suggests new representations of educational research, distinguished from education research by the valued use of the educational influences of individuals in their

own learning, that provide opportunity to see firsthand how educational research emerges from lived theory. He explains that valuing certain kinds of knowledge does not necessarily presume a denial or exclusion of other kinds of knowledge and explains

I continue to value insights from these theories as I deepen and extend my understandings of living educational theories and a living theory methodology with the evolution of the implications of asking, researching, and answering “How do I improve what I am doing?” (2008, p. 106)

Using this question as a guide in his work and life, and noticing the values that he expresses through his practices has allowed him to grow his knowledge base about teaching and learning in his social context. Using cycles of action research, he inquires into the validity of his findings and makes interpretations about his improvement. This is not the work of a lone researcher, however, but rather he seeks out what he terms, validation groups of colleagues (2008, p. 108) to test his interpretations and to help him see where his espoused values may be in contradiction with his practices. He explains that making his learning about his improvement explicit

also helped me to understand just how important it is, for the creation of valid explanations of educational influences in learning, to submit one’s own interpretations to a validation group to receive the benefit of the mutual, rational controls of the inter-subjective criticism of others. (Popper, 1975, p. 44, as cited in Whitehead, 2008, p. 107)

Engaging in the work of inquiring into practice, through action research cycles, through reflective journaling, or through personal examination using questions such as those provided in the previous section, is a starting point. Learning about self is the start of the process of learning to connect with others in service of teaching and learning. We suggest that mindful approaches to leadership, such as described in each of the three sections, starts with an examination of self, but always with the purpose of being able to engage more effectively with others to achieve the larger purpose of continually improving in our work, and the higher purpose of contributing to improving humanity through our work. Whitehead (2008) describes this new epistemology of living theory that “include flows of life affirming energy with values that carry hope for the future of humanity” (p. 103). We recognize this expression of a higher purpose in how we have each described a mindful approach to leadership. This living educational theory epistemology is useful for weaving the themes of this chapter, and it to this task that we now turn.

LIVING EDUCATIONAL THEORY: EMBODYING A MINDFUL APPROACH TO EDUCATIONAL LEADERSHIP

What if learning how to thrive, and helping others to do the same, is the central work of teaching and learning? (Cherkowski & Walker, 2013b) This chapter assimilates what this might look like by creating a collaborative living educational theory about mindful approaches to leadership. We started this chapter with the story of the Cracked Pot, as a reflection of what we see as a mindful approach to leadership, one in which the starting place is a deeper knowledge of self for the purpose of connecting more genuinely and with greater engagement with others in service of our work as teachers and learners. Often, the common story, or shared understanding, about leadership is that it is a process of influence through relationships toward a desired purpose (Rost, 1993). We have highlighted in each of our stories that the agency for cultivating relationships with our colleagues for the purpose of moving toward a desired purpose does not reside only in formal roles, but is accessible to each of us, and expressed differently according to how our educational influences inform our work in our own social contexts.

For example, Kelly's learning journey started with a self-study of how to improve her practice. She embarked on a reflective journaling adventure that awakened her to her living educational theory of self-awareness as essential to authentic collaboration. As she opened her mind, heart, and will to learning about how she reflected her values through her relationships with her colleague and her students, she was able to expose contradictions between her beliefs and her actions. From this space of compassionate awareness, she was able to make a choice about the stories she was telling herself in her work and about her work, and this led to a freedom to choose stories that empowered her to access her Higher Self in her work. Her mindful approach to leadership started from self, as she learned to notice and articulate her living educational theory, and moved toward learning how to engage more honestly, openly with her colleagues as she strived to learn how to improve her practice.

Jen's ongoing journey to learn how to improve her practice as an educational leader of professional learning in her own school context has also become an expression of her desire to connect, collaborate, and co-design meaningful learning with her colleagues. From a living educational theory perspective, she is coming to understand how theory and practice from the discipline of adult theory is interconnected with the theory from professional learning communities, and uses this knowledge to build her own emergent knowledge base about her experiences with professional learning. As she models the power of engaged professional learner with her colleagues, she is noticing that they too are becoming empowered to take notice of how they

can engage more deeply in their own professional learning. This mindful approach to educational leadership is beginning to bear fruit across schools as teachers engage more authentically in their own professional learning.

A living theory perspective can serve as a vehicle for understanding how to reflect our highest values in our work and in our life in contribution to a higher goal of improving humanity (DeLong, 2013; Whitehead, 1989; 2008). This perspective supports and reflects Sabre's description of how the Flourishing Model shifts the focus of improvement toward noticing what happens in schools as we pay attention to what makes us come alive in our work. The questions emerging from the Leaderful Mindset domain of that model reflect how she and her colleague have grounded their research in a critical mass of scholarship that encourages us to give enhanced attention to what is working, researching what gives life, focusing on what we want more of, and figuring out how to sustain all that results in thriving communities. The foundational question in a living theory perspective—how can I improve in my practice and in so doing contribute to a higher common ground of love and humanity?—resonates with Sabre and her colleagues' assumption that cultivating Leaderful Mindsets is an important aspect of developing life-giving learning communities within which students, their families, and the entire learning community can thrive. In other words, connecting to and learning about self as a leader is the starting point for connecting more honestly and openly with others as a way to encourage and sustain flourishing in schools.

Co-writing this chapter has influenced our ongoing learning about what it means to serve others as we move in and out of leadership roles in our work. We have noticed how, as we open ourselves to each other through attending with presence to each other as a writing team, we are each growing our capacity for developing a sense of wonder and curiosity and the power of inviting diverse perspectives that can lead to greater knowledge of self. Mindful approaches to leadership begin with an inquiry into and examination of the self. However this is not the end goal, but rather the starting point for engaging more genuinely, compassionately, and in an inspired way with our colleagues in service of improving our teaching and contributing to a higher common ground of improving humanity. Our stories, like "The Cracked Water Pot," remind us of the power and potential for mindful approaches to leadership as a way of connecting to each other through accessing our Highest Selves in our work and life.

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Chapter Five

Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education

Pedagogical Insights

Geoffrey Soloway

As noted in this volume, the integration of mindfulness into teaching and learning has garnered both pedagogical and research attention (Meiklejohn, Philips, Freedman, Griffin, Biegel et al., 2012; Davidson, Dunne, Eccles, Engle, Greenberg et al., 2012). I, as one of those curious, along with Dr. Corey Mackenzie and Dr. Patricia Poulin, developed an elective course within Teacher Education called Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education (MBWE). MBWE was taught within the context of an elective course in Teacher Education called Stress and Burnout: Teacher and Student Applications, focused on developing teachers' mindfulness, reducing stress and burnout, and enhancing overall well-being. We conducted two quasi-experimental studies looking at these outcomes with teachers-in-training (Poulin, Mackenzie, Soloway, & Karaoylas, 2008; Soloway, Mackenzie, & Poulin, 2010), and I completed a qualitative grounded theory study for my doctoral research on the MBWE program. This chapter highlights findings from my dissertation research pertaining to key pedagogical and curricular components of Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education (MBWE) program. Grounded theory findings from my dissertation highlighting the added value of MBWE in Teacher Education are reported elsewhere (Soloway, 2015). Multiple data points contributed to the analysis for this chapter, including twenty-three interviews with teacher candidates. More data was also collected in anonymous feedback forms completed twice within a course. Data was collected over the span of two years, running the MBWE course three times in following with an iterative action research design (Kemmis &

McTaggart, 1988; Schmuck, 2006). My own role as instructor, interacting with teacher candidates and reading course assignments also contributed to a better understanding of students’ experience of the course. Personal reflections kept after teaching MBWE classes, and while on a one-month silent meditation retreat (which reflects my own process learning mindfulness) also contributed to the findings in this chapter. Findings for this chapter are organized into the following three sections: (1) Assignments in MBWE, (2) Learning Mindfulness: Drawing on Past Experiences, and (3) Pedagogy of Well-Being.

ASSIGNMENTS IN MBWE

The process of action research stimulated many changes to course assignments in MBWE. For two years I conducted a formative evaluation of the program to improve all pedagogical components. Table 5.1 lists assignments that were developed to enhance learning in MBWE, followed by a fuller discussion of the assignment.

Intention for Course

Intention is a critical component for the MBWE course. Teacher candidates write an intention for the course based on their introduction to MBWE in week one. Teacher candidates ask themselves: what do I wish for myself to get out of this course? What areas of my health and well-being do I want to improve? What do I want to work on/gain/leave behind in my personal and professional life? Why do I think I am ready to take on this course? How will I learn best in this course? Students were further asked to outline one specific area in their life (i.e., dance, music, art, sports, etc.) that helps to relieve

Table 5.1. Assignments in Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education

Assignments in MBWE	Value
Intention for Course	5%
Professional Interview	5%
Personal Wellness Workbook	20%
Mindful Teaching Journal	10 %
Holistic Lesson Plan/ Teaching Mindfulness	10%
Presentation	10%
Self Study Final Paper	20%
Class Participation	20%

stress and supports them in feeling grounded, connected, and present. Additional questions to respond to include: Where will you be able to fit in a daily five- to twenty-minute mindfulness practice in your busy schedule? What will help you stay motivated and engaged in this personal and professional development program? Teacher candidates are encouraged to read over the assignments for this course, and outline their intention to complete them. Students are also encouraged to outline any variations to an assignment they would like to make, or to suggest alternative assignments that would better aid their learning.

The first week of MBWE is a thorough overview of the course. I consider week two the beginning of the program, which is why teacher candidates who choose to return for week two need to complete their intention for being in the course. Students may perceive a mindfulness-based course in the context of professional preparation as a *bird course*, which is why a comprehensive overview of the course in week one is necessary to dispel this myth. I would often tell teacher candidates that MBWE will be more work than other courses, and require a greater commitment on a daily basis. Further, I describe MBWE as a different type of work, distinct from the traditional courses in academic settings.

The intention assignment helps teacher candidates realize the in-depth personal and professional level of learning that will be required of them. As instructor, I am looking for the following components within the intention assignment: intrinsic motivation for being in the class, authentic voice and tone, genuine openness to the learning process in MBWE, relevant background experiences, and a plan for completing a regular mindfulness practices in their daily schedule. If I read an intention assignment that lacks clarity or enough focus I will ask students for more. My teaching approach provided a high level of support, and maintained a high level of expectation.

Professional Interview

The interview in MBWE became an integral part of the learning process. After students write their intention for the course, I have some time to read them, and then to meet with them to discuss it. This one-on-one professional interview takes place within the first three weeks of the course, outside of class time. This provides the instructor the opportunity to look more deeply into the students' motivations for taking the course, potential backgrounds that may be helpful in framing the learning process, and to nurture the teacher educator–teacher candidate relationship. The content of the interview is the intention assignment, the initial work done in the wellness workbook, and the teacher candidates' experience of the class thus far. Students have the opportunity to ask any questions they have, and practice interviewing in a professional manner.

During the interview with the students, I am looking to help make connections between students' background experience and mindfulness. Some of these connections are more clear than others. For example, some of the students are very open about having a diagnosed disorder or disease such as anxiety or depression. MBWE serves the role of being an outlet for these types of backgrounds, as well as support for new strategies for coping, but does not use a therapeutic approach. MBWE calls forth whatever is present in one's life, not for the purpose of fixing, but more simply as a way of developing awareness and acceptance. Being able to connect the potential value of practicing mindfulness with past struggles helps to build motivation for sincerely taking on the homework in the course.

Ultimately, the interview is an opportunity to solidify at least one reference point for each student from which to understand mindfulness. Sometimes the connection is very clear and other times it takes a little more time for it to unfold. This process of attuning with the student in the interview is a practice of staying present to them, and trusting a connection point will emerge. This special process has been a memorable experience, and demonstrates that the teacher-student relationship is not simply valuable within K–12 education, but is integral to all levels of education.

Personal Wellness Workbook

The personal wellness workbook is a guide for the Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education program. Composed of eight weeks, with each week corresponding to a particular dimension of the wellness wheel (see Figure 5.1, Wellness Wheel). The wellness workbook has undergone revisions throughout the years based on feedback from teacher candidates. On the introduction page of each week, there is a brief description of the topic for the week, space to fill weekly practices, reflective questions, and a space for weekly commitments. Reflections should include a focus on formal mindfulness practice, informal mindfulness practice, and wellness focus on the week. There are also reflective questions found on the introduction page to each week. The front and back of two colored pages (matching the theme of wellness) are left blank for teacher candidates to fill in a way that is meaningful for them. This may include journaling, art, literary quotes, poetry, etc. The number of pages per week was reduced in order to create a more balanced workload between written reflections, formal mindfulness practice, and reading articles.

There is also a Formal Mindfulness Practice Log for teacher candidates to fill in the practices and duration of practice they complete each week. The log provides a graphic representation for teacher candidates to track their mindfulness practice, and also provides the instructor greater insight into teacher candidates' process. The final page of each week offers space for teacher candidates to reflect on the readings. Teacher candidates are guided



Figure 5.1. Wellness Wheel. Created by author.

to reflect on their personal learning from the readings, and in also in relation to teaching, learning, and education. Teacher candidates are invited to bring their workbooks to class each week, and use it as a reference when sharing in small groups about their experience and learning from the week. Teacher candidates complete peer evaluations of the workbook on random weeks throughout the course. Evaluations are focused simply on completion, so teacher candidates are not reading other students' workbooks. The instructor evaluates workbooks more comprehensively during practicum. Even still, teacher candidates are able to mark areas of their workbook that they do not wish to be read.

Mindful Teaching Journal

During a four-week practicum, teacher candidates keep a journal of their formal mindfulness practice and informal enactment of mindfulness in the classroom. The primary purpose of this journal is to support teacher candidates in staying engaged with the experience of a mindfulness practice while teaching. Teacher candidates are expected to have two brief reflections per week. One reflection each week should be on the formal practice, and the other reflection focuses on the practice of mindful teaching while in the classroom. This assignment has become more focused on these two dimensions in order to support the continued formal practice and to foster the informal practice of being present in the classroom. Teacher candidates' act of reflecting on reflection-in-action in the journal brings forth insight into the value of being present in the classroom. The quotation below comes from Chandra, a teacher candidate describing her experience of practicing mindfulness on practicum.

Briefly before my two classes, I sometimes did a short loving kindness practice and I noticed that my behavior inside the classroom and outside the classroom changed completely. Students were very receptive to this caring nature and I noticed that I needed less classroom management because of this. When I first started my practicum, I thought I had to be very strict in order to have effective classroom management. I realized students were more receptive to kind and assertive communication. I also noticed that I was more calm and patient with students in the classroom and during extra help sessions. I believe my calm nature caused the students to act calmer.

The mindful teaching journal develops the momentum started during the MBWE class into the four-week practicum (This Teacher Education program was structured so a course ran for six weeks, students went off practicum for four weeks, and then returned to complete the Teacher Education course for four weeks). Journals are handed in upon return from practicum, and evaluated based on completion and quality of reflections. Quality is based on reflections being on topic, such as describing a moment in the classroom when they felt present, versus a synopsis of their day teaching.

Holistic Lesson Plan

The holistic lesson plan was a new assignment introduced to apply learning from MBWE in the areas of holistic teaching. Holistic teaching is introduced through various readings such as Miller's (1994) *Holistic Curriculum*, and exercises involving the wellness wheel. The wellness wheel is used to explore a holistic approach to classroom planning; placing classroom planning in the center of the wellness wheel and having teacher candidates outline elements of the classroom relating to each dimension of wellness. The well-

ness wheel is also used to demonstrate an integrative curriculum. In this exercise, teacher candidates put a specific topic they are going to be teaching on practicum in the center of the wheel, and write down elements of that topic relating to each dimension of wellness.

On practicum, teacher candidates use their creativity in developing and teaching a holistic lesson. This may include (however is not limited to) the integration of a mindfulness-based practice with students. Upon returning from practicum, teacher candidates hand in their lesson plan and a reflection on their experience teaching the class, and on what makes that lesson holistic. In addition to handing in this assignment, teacher candidates present their experience of the holistic lesson in small groups in class the first day back from practicum. Below, Audrey, a teacher candidate, shares her perspective of holistic education as she completes MBWE.

I really became fascinated with the proposal for holistic education. Prior to my experience in teacher education, the only theories of education and pedagogies I have encountered are the ones that I have experienced first hand. Looking back at my elementary education, the curriculum presented a very fragmented perspective. Our classes and subjects were very disconnected and it was expected that we would make those connections at some point on our own. Holistic education looks at not only connecting the curriculum naturally, but also connecting the students with their work through collaboration, and merging reason and intuition.

This reflection illustrates the importance of learning holistically in MBWE, learning about theory of holistic education, and the opportunity to engage in developing holistic learning opportunities over practicum.

Presentation

The presentation in MBWE dramatically changed since its first inception. The original design of the presentation assignment was completed in groups of four or five within a thirty-minute timeframe. The presentation used to focus on one possible source of stress for teachers, and on the applicability of mindfulness and wellness-based approaches for managing this source of stress. Presentations took up a considerable amount of time in the original format, for both preparation time in groups, and for the presentations themselves. Time allotted didn't bring forth equivalent value in learning because of the size of the group and lack of personal content. Further, teacher candidates did not seem very engaged in their presentations, and as an instructor, I did not find the quality of work advancing learning in the class.

The first year instructing MBWE for the cohort of students participating in this study there was no presentation assignment. The importance of teacher candidates sharing their own personal and professional learning in the

form of presentation came back into focus listening to holistic lesson plans and informal discussions lead by students. A key moment of insight about the presentation came through an informal discussion with Todd, a teacher candidate, speaking about his experience of mindfulness through sports, and specifically as it relates to hockey.

I had a unique connection to Todd because we played as defense partners on the school hockey team. I organized the education school's hockey team so filling spots on the team with students in MBWE was a natural beginning. Since starting the team, there was between one and three students from MBWE on the hockey team. Having the opportunity for more informal conversations, Todd showed an interest in the connections between mindfulness and hockey. I invited Todd to lead a discussion in class about his insights on the topic. His discussion fostered classroom engagement and learning in a unique way, one that needed to be facilitated on a more regular basis.

The resurgence of the presentation in MBWE became an individual learning and teaching opportunity on a topic of choice related to mindful wellness. Within the new format, presentations are ten minutes and cover three areas: personal connection to the topic, experience in the course practicing mindful wellness in relation to the topic, and a research article on the topic. Examples of topics include: dance, depression, running, laughter yoga, fishing, anxiety, and family alcoholism. It is important for teacher candidates to choose a topic that has personal significance, and an area they can investigate through their own practice throughout the course. I found teacher candidates enthusiastic about their topics, and eager to explore and present them. Following each presentation, other students in the class are invited to ask a question or make a comment in response. Presentations have become a valuable community learning experience where each student becomes the teacher, and has the opportunity to share a unique approach to learning mindfulness.

Final Self-Study Research Paper

The final paper also underwent considerable change over the course of this study. This assignment is now a five-page synthesis of the personal and professional learning that emerged throughout MBWE, compared to a two-page personal wellness plan. The content and structure were changed in order to provide teacher candidates with a more in-depth opportunity to synthesize their learning in the course. As well, the current assignment models aspects of self-study research methodology (Loughran, 2002), which provides an opportunity for teacher candidates to gain experience in this approach of research which can be useful later on in their teaching career. It is expected that teacher candidates develop their paper from common themes identified after reading through all their course work, and include citations referencing key theoretical points. The following questions guide the final paper: What

has been your learning journey going through the Mindfulness-Based Wellness Education program? What did you learn about yourself and were areas of personal growth? What did you learn about teaching, learning, and education, and what were the areas of professional growth? How are these things connected?

Teacher candidates bring their final paper to the last class and are given an opportunity to edit each other's papers. This provides another opportunity for continuing to share learning experiences in the course, and exchange feedback between one's peers. Final papers are often inspired pieces of writing, where teacher candidates grapple with various issues and in the process of writing, gain new insights into their learning process. For example, below a teacher candidate articulates her personal growth in her final paper.

This program helped me in a special way. My father passed away 14 years ago, and I never came to an understanding around issues/worries I created in my mind; wishing I could have done or said something to him to save him from a tragic death. Life went on and I am here today gaining the strength I need to live in harmony with my mind, moving forward with life, allowing myself to accept and deal with my emotions differently, in a calmer manner. This effects who I am, and who I am in the classroom.

Blending personal and professional perspectives in the final paper is a novel form of writing for teacher candidates, calling them to move beyond writing as a static abstraction and seeing themselves within the lucidity of the experience. This approach to writing is another form of praxis in MBWE, often more engaging for the writer and for the reader.

METAPHORS FOR LEARNING MINDFULNESS: DRAWING ON PAST EXPERIENCES

Teacher candidates come to appreciate mindfulness from their own diverse set of experiences. As the instructor of this program, it is essential to acknowledge this diversity and develop a conception of mindfulness that builds upon prior experience. "Metaphors for Teaching Mindfulness," below, lists various backgrounds that were identified as relevant for teacher candidates in learning mindfulness. For example, a number of teacher candidates identified with the practice of yoga when taking MBWE. Teacher candidates entering MBWE who had some experience in yoga entered the course with a greater sense of openness, and less initial resistance to the content focus. This makes sense considering that mindfulness and yoga are philosophically related and yoga is traditionally taught as a mindfulness practice.

Metaphors for Teaching Mindfulness

- Yoga
- Dance
- Discipline of Psychology/Philosophy
- Drama
- Jogging
- Hockey
- Martial Arts

I found that students with a background in philosophy and psychology also come into the class with a more open perspective toward this work because they have experience thinking deeply about issues related to human experience. I try as much as possible to highlight these theoretical backgrounds, and to bring them into dialogue within the principles and practice of the mindfulness program. This only serves to broaden the scope of student engagement. The same could also be said of students who describe a background in the sciences. These students are typically helpful in clarifying the research being done on mindfulness within their own scientific field. Encouraging these students to investigate the literature on mindfulness is a good strategy for encouraging a plurality of interests within the group.

Different activities were helpful in relating with teacher candidates, for example, dance, jogging, and fishing. Beginning from an activity that makes sense to teacher candidates supports them in connecting their own experience of that activity with mindfulness. For example, dance is a relevant background to draw upon, because dance is a body-based activity that includes repeated attention to one's breath. Drama is another relevant background in relation to the present moment awareness in acting and working with the emotional awareness of the character they are playing. Breathing practices are also commonly used in preparation for drama. By situating mindfulness practices within these various disciplines, the course gradually succeeds in becoming more tangible to the various members of the class. Even to those who do not partake of such practices, the experience of their peers often serve as helpful metaphors for accessing their own relationship to the practice of mindfulness.

Physical activities such as running were also commonly shared by many teacher candidates. Runners can identify with the mental discipline the sport requires, and finding a sense of flow while running. *Flow* is a concept introduced by Csikszentmihályi (1997), referring to a state of being totally present in what one is doing. Flow is characterized by the perception of slowing down and being more aware of the body. Many teacher candidates participating in sports such as hockey, soccer, or baseball, for example, identified with the concept of flow, and it supported their understanding of mindfulness in the context of their sport or activity. Learning mindfulness through an activ-

ity that teacher candidates are already versed in, helps them transfer learning into other activities in their life, as well as to the formal mindfulness practices such as sitting meditation or mindful yoga. There are numerous examples of elite athletes using the practice of mindfulness as well as the concept of flow for enhancing their performance. For example, Phil Jackson, a world renowned basketball coach of the Chicago Bulls and L.A. Lakers incorporated mindfulness with his players, as did the 2014 Superbowl champions Seattle Seahawks.

My own experience on meditation retreat helped me to better understand the practice of mindfulness and running. When I was sitting a month-long silent mindfulness retreat at the Insight Meditation Center in Barre Massachusetts, I began a jogging routine. I am not exactly *light on my feet*, carrying around 190 pounds on a 5'9" frame, and with a history of hip disease. This description is trying to illustrate that I don't easily find flow in my running stride. While on meditation retreat I had a routine loop that I would run that included a few inclines. My practice of staying present in meditation transferred into my running as I began to notice that when I began running up a hill my mind would shift to a thought or fantasy in order to escape the unpleasantness of running up the hill. I would find myself at the top of the hill without being present throughout the process of getting there. Often, in meditation practice and in life, we tune out when something becomes difficult. This example from running helped me see when I was tuning out, which I could then transfer into other areas of my life.

Fishing was another unique background explored when learning mindfulness. A student named Simon highlighted fishing in his intention assignment, and with him I was able to explore a number of valuable connections between fishing and mindfulness during our one-on-one professional interview. Simon was excited by this exploration and took on the practice of mindful fishing. Simon was then able to grasp mindfulness through the example of staying present to the feel of the fishing line between his fingers, and how his attentiveness influenced his performance and the quality of his experience. I mention this singular case to emphasize the way in which individual experiences can often provide helpful models and metaphors for the rest of the participants in the course. Through Simon's interests, the course went on to develop and sustain a number of helpful comparisons between mindfulness in general and the particularities of Simon's experiences of fishing. Catch and release, for example, became a repeating theme throughout the course furthering our understanding of working with thoughts.

Connecting the experience of mindfulness to an existing background is a key pedagogical strategy for enhancing engagement in MBWE. The list of backgrounds presented in this chapter does not represent an exclusive list of relevant background for learning mindfulness. Rather, they are examples of how teacher candidates were able to draw on their past experiences in order

to better understand mindfulness. Indeed, mindfulness can be understood from many diverse background experiences as it has to do with a way of being that can be accessed in any activity. This finding is relevant to those teaching mindfulness in professional preparation, and other contexts, where students may be required to take such a course, and/or initially enter the course without familiarity or with high degrees of skepticism toward the course content. Helping to relate the concept and practice of mindfulness to existing ideas and activities is very much in line with a constructivist approach to learning. The course development does not start from a clean slate, but emerges from working with the prior experiences of those in the classroom.

PEDAGOGY OF WELL-BEING

As the curriculum for MBWE continued to evolve with new topics, assignments, and ways of being together in the classroom, a new framework for the course emerged. The following three categories were developed as learning outcomes for the MBWE program: (1) Mindful Teaching, (2) Teaching Mindfulness, and (3) Pedagogy of Well-Being. The first of these categories, Mindful Teaching, refers to teacher candidates learning to be patient, inclusive, and adaptable in the classroom, as well as present, caring, and resilient in professional relationships. Teaching Mindfulness addresses the actual implementation of mindfulness-based learning within a classroom setting. This might include teaching both formal or informal mindfulness exercises—activities that might address the cultivation of attentiveness in students. The third category, Pedagogy of Well-Being, is a broad construct encompassing the integration of mindful wellness into a teacher's philosophy and practice in the classroom. Pedagogy includes teachers' underlying beliefs and worldview, and the incorporation of their beliefs and worldview into their selection and preparation of activities, materials, and assignments (Darling-Hammond, Banks, Zumwalt, Gomez, et al., 2005). A pedagogy of well-being includes both mindful teaching and teaching mindfulness. This additional element moves the purpose of mindfulness training for teachers beyond a strategy for stress reduction or a technique to implement with students in the classroom. Pedagogy of well-being is a learning objective of the MBWE program that cultivates a more holistic and integrative approach to teaching and learning. Developing one's pedagogy of well-being is a dynamic process that matures in the ongoing personal and professional learning of the teacher. This process looks different for each teacher, given diversity in their personal backgrounds, teaching contexts, and subject matter. Figure 5.2 illustrates a model of pedagogy of well-being.

Within previous educational models, curricular development was conceived of through a number of discrete subjects such as math, science or English. A teacher entered the field with proven specialty within a given area; their classroom focus was then defined within the parameters of this subject. More recently, there has been a strong push to consider the question of curriculum within a broader field of considerations. Curricular initiatives in education are broadening in scope to include, for example, Social and Emotional Learning (SEL), Environmental Education, Global Citizenship Education (GCE), and Healthy Schools. Although not all of these initiatives are being taken up within one school district or fall under the same name, a mandate within many boards and ministries of education are emerging in North America that reflect a deeper commitment toward these broadened curricular initiatives.

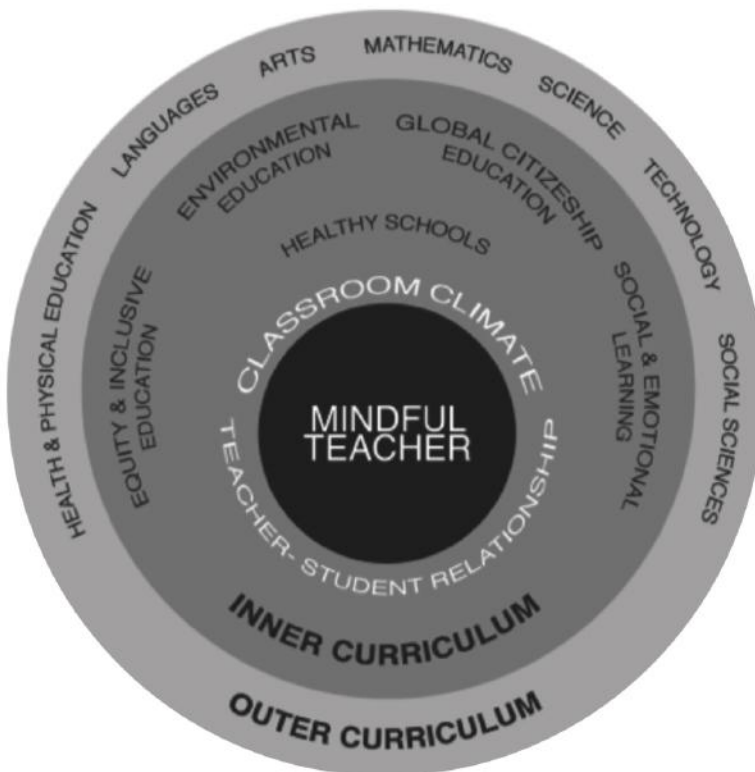


Figure 5.2. Pedagogy of Well-Being. Created by author.

One common element within this expanding curriculum is they share a focus on the inner life in relation to the outer world, hence being referred to here as the *inner curriculum*. The inner curriculum is not typically found as separate courses in K–12 education or Teacher Education, nor is it reported on as stringently in student assessment as compared to outer curriculum. MBWE uses the wellness wheel as a model by which to understand the diversity of our exchanges between the so-called inner and outer worlds, and thus is seen as a model for developing content knowledge for the inner curriculum.

Integrating the inner and outer curriculums is learning to infuse a focus from the inner curriculum with an outer curricular focus, i.e., teaching math through a social justice perspective or instructing a lesson on literacy through a social and emotional learning lens. How this is taken up in the classroom is left to be defined by the teacher in his or her own class and depends on their own content knowledge of the inner and outer curriculum. Appendix A is an example of a teacher candidate developing their pedagogy of well-being as illustrated by a lesson plan they developed on practicum. This model is primarily trying to illustrate a way teacher candidates can approach their understanding of teaching in a more holistic way—an approach that integrates current curricular initiatives of well-being with core curricular subjects.

Teachers learn to bridge the inner and outer curriculum through principles, practices, and perspectives of mindful wellness learned through their own experience of the inner curriculum. Key principles such as interdependence, compassion, nonjudgment, uncertainty, balance, and inclusivity are learned in relation to one's own life and then infused into their design of lessons. Teachers can draw upon diverse perspectives in bringing together the inner and outer curriculum such as Self – Subject – Community or Mind – Body – Environment perspectives highlighted by Miller (1994) in his conception of a holistic curriculum. Further, teachers can use transformative practices in bridging the inner and outer curriculum such as breathing exercises, visualization, art, music, and movement. Mindfulness is increasingly becoming a buzz word in education as districts are seeking out training and curriculum on *how to do* mindfulness in the classroom. This notion of a pedagogy of well-being reminds us that mindfulness is both something we can be as teachers, a specific tool we can implement in our classrooms with students, and in its most complex form, a way of teaching and learning that can be integrated into the design and delivery of all lessons.

LITERACY OF MINDFULNESS

The MBWE program is founded on the conviction that the well-being of students begins with the well-being of their instructors. The process of personal and professional learning in MBWE contemplates how looking in, shifts the way we are able to see out. Teachers must not only be knowledgeable in the core curricular subjects they teach, but also prepared for a more holistic educational perspective in the twenty-first century that includes the inner life of the student. Best practice for speaking to the inner curriculum in one's classroom is speaking from one's own inner experience. Integrating mindful wellness into Teacher Education is not going to suddenly stop the many challenges teachers face on a daily basis in the classroom; however, new knowledge, skills, and ways of being developed will enable them to respond at a more sophisticated level.

Mindfulness is a literacy we are all capable of developing through practice. Just like learning to read a book, mindfulness is a literacy of learning to read the present moment as it is—minus the storylines we typically attach to experience. This includes a clearer understanding of one's emotions as well as the emotions of others. Similar to the way learning to read forever shifted the trajectory of human beings, learning mindfulness plays a unique role in the continual evolution of our species. Over the past thirty years we have witnessed the growth of mindfulness-based training and its benefits toward health and well-being in adult populations. The next thirty years is on a path toward uncovering the role of mindfulness in education and human development. And finally, as mindfulness becomes a more central initiative in education, teachers and students will begin to tap into a vast human potential, and continue to *unfold* areas of the brain, and capacities of heart and mind.

APPENDIX A: DEVELOPING A PEDAGOGY OF WELL-BEING;
HOLISTIC LESSON PLAN

In one particular lesson, in a grade 9 Canadian geography class on “declining fisheries in Canada,” I was successful in incorporating effectively a holistic approach to teaching that appealed and engaged the entire class.

The lesson began in setting a positive, secure, and safe atmosphere by asking the students to sit up straight and de-clutter their desks. I ask them to forget about their stresses and personal agendas and to sit silently and listen to a poem that I had chosen to share with the class. The poem was from a book entitled “Coastlines: The Poetry of Atlantic Canada” by Ross Leckie and it vividly described Canada's breath-taking Atlantic coastline featuring fisheries. The students were given the choice to either close their eyes and in their minds imagine the landscape, or look at the photos that I had prepared

in a slide show. The goal of this exercise was to show students that we are related to nature and should be grateful and respect its natural beauty. I believed that this introduction calmed the class down dramatically and captured their interest in the topic.

In the next activity, I took an interactive poll which asked students how many times they consume fish products daily, weekly, and monthly. This class-wide poll illustrated to students the relevancy of the fishing industry in their personal lives. Students very much enjoyed this exercise because they were able to express an opinion and have discussions with fellow peers. The aim of this activity was to indirectly show to students that there is a clear and important interdependent relationship and unity among people and the environment. In conducting this activity, students were able to see a crucial and fragile relationship between humans and the fishing industry.

In order to examine further the issue of declining fisheries in Canada, students were asked to get into groups of three or four in order to complete a graphic organizer. This activity asked students to work cooperatively with one another by communicating, sharing and imparting knowledge from course resources. Students very much enjoyed this activity and learned from one another instead of being told knowledge (linear transmission) by the teacher. In addition, the lesson included students to read and answer questions pertaining to a newspaper article written on a controversial issue regarding “Aquaculture” in Canada. I chose this particular article because it reinforced the important connection and impact humanity has on the environment. To conclude the lesson, I asked students to reflect and write about what they learned, felt, and experienced during the lesson and what questions did they still have on the subject.

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Chapter Six

Mindful Curricular Engagement

Preparing Prospective Educators to See/Act with Discernment and Deliberation

Margaret Macintyre Latta

If there is ever a place for mindful engagement, a place to practice mindful engagement, it should be within educative contexts. It is the responsibility of educative contexts to move students' minds/bodies/spirits—fostering interactions, deliberations, and debates, about what it means to teach and to learn. Enabling students to gain critical awareness, agency, and conscious engagement with the world is the needed educator mindfulness entailed within the awesome responsibility of moving minds/bodies/spirits. This responsibility is what calls my interest as an educator, and what this chapter pursues. In particular, this chapter turns to the integral role of field experiences for prospective educators toward instilling such lived understandings of mindful engagement within teaching/learning situations of all kinds.

Classrooms and schools are often structured so that students and teachers race between brief disconnected lessons. In many of these settings, I observe students pulling stuff out of backpacks, then jamming it back into backpacks, moving from class to class at a hectic pace, ensuring that they race at a speed that has everyone arriving and departing each class on time so as not to be penalized. The race for many students and their families continues after school with activities such as soccer practice, piano class, and then a return trip home for supper and a massive search for the worksheet from math class at the bottom of the backpack, which needs to be completed before the race starts again the next day. Similar scenarios are played out across educative sites of all kinds extending beyond traditional K–12 settings to higher education, sports, arts, and leisure pursuits invested in predetermined outcomes/

products with little attention to differences and processes in relation to outcomes/products. The mindless cycles that typify many of these pursuits are termed “endemic” by Hargreaves and Shirley (2009). They describe how orienting curricular enactment primarily toward effective management of students from activity to activity, subject matter to subject matter, and mastery level to mastery level produces such endemic preoccupations (pp. 2505–534). Akin to Hargreaves and Shirley, other researchers describe such endemic preoccupations as the “increasing intensification” of teaching (See for example: Apple, 1986; Ballet & Kelchtermans, 2008) resulting in little-to-no room to foster moving minds through interaction, deliberation, and debate. For all involved, room to concomitantly see and act, moving thinking accordingly, is difficult to find, and thus not practiced. In fact, such opportunities are more apt to be rare occurrences. For prospective educators, this lack of room to negotiate mindful teaching identities has a troublesome history with persistent underestimated costs. As a teacher educator, the lack of room for practicing mindful engagement conveys messages that I am very uncomfortable with as an educative stance for prospective educators.

CONTEXTS IN SUPPORT OF MINDFULNESS

I characterize predominant education policies and practices concerned with standardization, evaluation, and control, as being hugely violent to teachers and to students, restricting room for mindful engagement. I find “violent” to be a fitting term, portraying how such policies and practices negate self-understandings and thwart room to adapt, make, and build understandings (Macintyre Latta, 2013). Over one hundred years ago, Dewey (1910) referred to how subject matter taught “as an accumulation of ready-made material with which students are to be made familiar” betrays subject matter taught “as an attitude of mind, after the pattern of which mental habits are to be transformed” (p. 183). At the crux of the betrayal is the age-old question, *What counts as knowledge?* Knowledge understood as a noun—something to be transmitted to students—positions learners as receivers of knowledge. Knowledge understood as a verb—adapting, changing, and building meaning—positions learners as creators of knowledge. The lived terms of knowledge as a noun or knowledge as a verb orient curricular enactment very differently.

The lived terms of knowledge as a noun are concerned with compliance and uniformity, emphasizing covering/acquiring content and/or transferring knowledge. The lived terms of knowledge as a verb are concerned with what minds bring to every curricular situation, drawing on the varied connections and interpretations we each see and understand in all matters. Making these connections and interpretations visible and then adapting, changing, and

building meaning—moving minds/bodies/spirits becomes curricular enactment’s task. It is the ensuing movement of individual/collective thinking at the heart of what it means to educate that I desire prospective educators to concomitantly see with and act upon. The mindful seeing such curricular engagement demands forms resourceful terrain for engaged concerted action; the subject matter matters—action that actually matters to students/teachers. But, as attention to this mindful movement is often foreign to educators and their students and discouraged in many educative contexts, the room to do so is vastly limited. Therefore, despite field experiences’ centrality within teacher education programs worldwide, prospective teachers do not necessarily find many opportunities to see moving minds in action, nor room to practice and hone the needed capacities to do so (see for example: Bai, Donald, & Scott, 2009; Macintyre Latta & Field, 2005; O’Connell Rust, 2009).

UNPACKING FIELD EXPERIENCES’ INTEGRAL ROLES

It is fitting for teacher education programs to acknowledge the importance of field experiences within the process of learning to teach. After all, teaching must be enacted. But the roles and lived terms of field experiences for teacher education programs and the associated students, faculty, and school/community personnel involved, has a persistent, problematic history in teacher education reform. Returning to the question of what counts as knowledge, field experiences are similarly understood as a transfer problem between theory and practice, plaguing field experiences in two interrelated ways. First, the theory/practice transfer problem within teacher education is well documented (see Darling-Hammond, 2006; Korthagen, 2001; Schoenfeld, 1999; Zeichner, 2006) and yet the traditional “application-of-theory model” persists in schools of education and within their relationships to field settings, despite little empirical evidence of improved teaching practices and student achievement (see for example: Grossman, 2008; Leiberan & Pointer-Mace, 2008; Wilson, Floden, & Ferrini-Mundy, 2002). Second, field settings do not allow much room for prospective teachers to actually practice theories within action (see for example: Bullough, 1997; Cochran-Smith & Lytle, 2009; Groundwater-Smith & Mockler, 2009). Instead, theory is often viewed as separated from the practice of teaching in field settings, with learning to teach navigated as an act of management through predetermined learning goals and behavior expectations. This view dominates conceptions of teaching practice in field settings, even though it is clear that the act of teaching is impoverished through the lens of theory/practice transfer.

Dewey (1904) called attention to the problematic relation of theory to practice in learning to teach many years ago. He argued for field experiences

to foster working conjunctures allowing both theory and practice to shape from within teaching/learning situations, what teachers do in classrooms and why. Locating such theory/practice conjunctures entails building relationships between self, others, and subject matter. A teacher's capacity to create the necessary conditions and attend to these conjunctures takes much concrete practice. As Dewey (1904) explains, "To be able to keep track of the mental play, to recognize the signs of its presence or absence, and to test apparent results by it, is the supreme mark and criteria of a teacher" (p. 14). But, the risks entailed in entering and traversing these conjunctures are more apt to be skirted in learning to teach. Many thinkers embrace the risky deliberations and interactions as the necessary moving forces to be grappled with as the primary opportunity of education (see: Biesta, 2004; Carr, 2000; Dewey, 1938; Dunne, 1997; Macintyre Latta & Crichton, 2015; Phelan & Sumsion, 2008; Zajonc, 2005). Biesta points out how these opportunities are not about the constituents of the teacher-learner relationship but about the relationality of the relationship (p. 13). Therefore, education lives in-between teacher and learner. Terming such in-betweenness "mind the gap," he argues that this gap is not something to be overcome but indeed what makes education possible (p. 13). It is concern for the contingencies afforded through the negotiation of the gap itself, living within the theory/practice conjunctures, which I envision as the needed mindfulness prospective teachers must cultivate and embrace.

REFRAMING FIELD EXPERIENCES

I approach field experiences as an important opportunity to challenge prospective educators' perceptions of teaching and begin to cultivate teaching identities with growing cognizance of living within theory/practice conjunctures concretely experiencing the deep responsibilities and associated mindfulness entailed. I envision prospective educators from across disciplines and interests of all kinds inquiring into what it means to engage learners in educative settings, and to begin to confront and understand the social, cultural, personal, contextual, and historical relational complexities at play within all educative settings. Therefore, I introduce the field experience to twenty prospective educators and two elementary school sites, sixteen practicing teachers and associated school administrators, as being purposefully designed to offer opportunities for prospective educators to mindfully negotiate curricular enactment, seeing and acting to engage students within learning. The two school sites and personnel involved commit to this shared purpose for twenty prospective educators, with field experiences bringing to life the questions and challenges of learning to teach. All agree to greater openness to such explorations for prospective educators much less focused on perform-

ing as a teacher, with much room to navigate multiple ways to be a teacher, experiencing the responsibility for thinking about and practicing discerning ways that might lead to mindful engagement on everyone's parts.¹

The selected elementary school sites and cooperating teachers agree to support concrete opportunities for prospective educators to negotiate many ways to be a teacher. They support positioning prospective educators to live at the conjunctures of theory and practice and, as such, practice mindful curricular engagement. After all, prospective educators' capacities to see fundamentally what is at stake in particular curricular situations—of what matters and why, the interactions arising, what their students are interested in and know, what shape curricular enactment takes and why, and continually confronting where they stand and how they feel about and negotiate being caught up in the unfolding action around them—is an integral part of becoming a teacher. Prospective educators must get concrete practice discerning and deliberating within these situated dimensions of curricular enactment. Gaining access to these inherent relational complexities within theory/practice conjunctures are integral to learning to teach and at the core of mindful curricular engagement.

Working in association with the two elementary school sites and sixteen associated practicing teachers, we agree to support experiential, situated dimensions of curricular enactment to foreground the role of relational complexities in classrooms for prospective teachers. As a teacher educator, I meet weekly in a seminar setting at each school site with prospective educators focused on a theorizing language for mindful curricular engagement. The aim is to position prospective educators to articulate and negotiate the lived curricular consequences towards greater tangibility and possibility. It is my hope that the lived terms enable mindful engagement and instill embodied understandings. Cooperating teachers try to support and nurture these efforts and I visit classrooms regularly, observing prospective educators' efforts closely and unpacking their distinct efforts on an ongoing basis. The associated seminars begin to articulate the costly consequences of not doing so through unpacking together how learner multiplicities get discounted when teaching/learning orients toward monolithic curriculum resulting in generic learning processes and products. Creating the necessary conditions and enabling prospective teachers to gain cognizance of these costs is very slow work, mindfully navigating the given multiplicities and complexities of any educative situation as the relational complexities integral within all curricular tasks. In part, it is slow work because the lived consequences of such engagement are often foreign or estranged to prospective educators. Such estrangement is often the case for the teachers and schools these prospective teachers are working alongside as well. And yet, relational complexities are what generate the movement of thought, as teachers and students constantly question what is seen and acted upon. It is the found vitality inherent within

relational complexities that reorients curricular enactment. So, as relational complexities hold the potential for bringing discernment and deliberation forward as primary to seeing/acting mindfully within teaching/learning situations, the slow work is most worthy and continues.

REFRAMING EDUCATION: CURRICULUM ENGAGEMENT AS MINDFUL PRACTICE

Drawing on varied traditions and perspectives, a shared characterization of mindfulness in the research literature is conscious awareness and acceptance of the present (Ie, Ngnoumen, & Langer, 2014). Mindful curricular engagement, then, entails ongoing attention to the needed pedagogical conditions to attend to the given movement of thinking. Curriculum, conceived as a movement of thinking, positions all participants to enter into learning as meaning-makers. The conceptual underpinnings of curriculum are grounded in genuine inquiry into what is worth knowing, rather than simply a curricular document. Curriculum is then lived and co-created in classrooms alongside students. Such curricular enactment embraces mind as verb, seeking a movement of thinking engaging all involved to adapt, change, build, and make meaning. Mindfulness is central to curricular engagement if educators create, attend, and sustain moving minds/bodies/spirits.

So, field experiences must be opportunities to enable prospective educators' mindfulness toward the individual/collective movement of thinking within curricular enactment, demanding attentiveness to the present, understanding that the past is alive in the present, holding implications for the future. Dewey (1938) provides insight into how integral such understanding of the present is in education through his explanation of the notion of preparation and its temporal nature:

When preparation is made at the controlling end, then the potentialities of the present are sacrificed to a suppositious future. When this happens, the actual preparation for the future is missed or distorted. The ideal of using the present simply to get ready for the future contradicts itself. It omits, and even shuts out, the very conditions by which a person can be prepared for his [sic] future. (p. 49)

This is not to say that the future is not important, as Dewey claims it “is not an Either-Or affair. The present affects the future anyway” (p. 50). But, if it is an educator's responsibility to see and create the present circumstances to positively impact the future, then the present of any given classroom moment demands attention. Dewey refers to this temporal educative relation as “an ever-present process” (p. 50).

The temporality at play within the ever-present process demands prospective educators reside mindfully at the nexus of theory/practice conjunctions within ongoing curricular situations and interactions. Opportunities extended to prospective teachers to reside accordingly, draw attention to four interrelated features identified by Davey (2006) as informing this past-present-future movement. Davey explains how these features surface varied perspectives and understandings, accept that all understandings are never final, attend to the past-present-future interplay within all given moments, and envision the potential within all given situations. And, it is these features that I find characterize prospective teachers' journeys toward mindful curricular engagement. Representative accounts chronicle how residing as such fosters heightened awareness of the choices that prospective educators make and their consequences for learning (MacDonald & Shirley, 2009), attending to the conditions and ongoing creation of mindful learning contexts.

1. "The ability to discern and to reside within the space between different interpretive horizons of understandings" (Davey, 2006, p. 60).

Davey's attention to horizons of understandings refers to Gadamer's (2000) acknowledgment of individual ranges of vision (p. 302). It is this range of visions and the growing awareness of how the horizon of the present is continually in process through room to negotiate one's range of vision, that Elli a prospective teacher in a grade one classroom, locates and negotiates.

Being first in line for recess, first in line for moving between classrooms, and first in line for teacher attention, arises as a concern of Elli's as she practices teaching in this grade one classroom. Elli positions her students to consider why "being first" is not always the best way to proceed. She feels very strongly that learning is thwarted as students preoccupied with being first undermine efforts to engage all students in learning. She enters into this consideration with her students by reading a story, *Me First*, by Helen Lester.

Elli draws all students closely around her to see the book's illustrations and hear the unfolding tale. She relays to the class that this story is a personal favorite and her obvious love of the tale comes across as she reads it aloud. Students attend with much interest and as Elli interrupts her telling with questions asking students to anticipate events, examine illustrations, and bring their personal experiences to bear, collective interest in the consideration of *Me First* is very evident. This interest is developed further as students are asked to generate their own related stories. Students can do so through illustrating their story, writing their story, or a combination of approaches.

The reading aloud of *Me First* alongside the considerations raised throughout the account prompts many ideas for personal connections leading to further story development. Students work on their own to develop a story concerning the issues raised in *Me First*. One of the students tells Elli his writing is "How he got ideas." Elli comments to me that she is struck by the significance of this statement by a grade one student. She keeps pondering this statement as she

moves between students, attending to their ideas and offering guidance as warranted. As students' stories are well underway, Elli has them share their accounts thus far with a buddy. The purposeful excitement is visible and tangible in the classroom. Elli reminds the class as a whole to really listen for each other's ideas about being first and refers to the one student's statement about his writing prompting his ideas. Another student responds with, "Me too." As the lesson unfolds further, Elli is able to surface individual student's horizons of learning and begin to map out some common collective considerations complicating the dilemmas of *me first* in her classroom.

As Elli and I talk following the conduct of the lesson, we revisit the terrain of her curricular enactment, discussing the ways she engages her students in learning throughout and why she did so. We discuss how the roles of personal connections, drawing on students' narratives of experiences, gained more visibility and formed the insights she gained for proceeding with her lesson. I emphasize the importance of her attention to her student's statement about his generation of ideas and the way in which she built on this statement with the others. Together we talk about such seeing and acting as a mindful teaching mode, attending to curricular making's elemental connectedness to being human, bringing varied narratives of experiences to bear. Discerning and residing within varied horizons of students' understandings are key to cultivating Elli's mindfulness. A fusion of horizons across students and Elli is clearly in the making and Elli is acquiring a depth of understanding as to the importance of continuing to build on this lesson with her students, looking for ways to return to and further consider the many issues prompted through *Me First*. Elli's access to concretely experience how human beings are fundamentally meaning makers, forms the needed room for her to practice. And, with much more practice, the curiosities, ensuing suggestions, and curricular directions that emerge, will increasingly be discerned as elemental human resources holding the genesis for continued mindful inquiry of all kinds. (Field Notes, 09/14/12)

2. "The ability to become sufficiently experienced to know that whatever past, present, or future experience presents, no experience is definitive: there is always more to be said and more to be understood" (Davey, 2006, p. 60).

Davey relays a comfort with the ever-growing texture of all knowledge. It is this texture that Pam encounters through curricular enactment and starts to negotiate what this entails for herself as teacher, alongside her students.

Pam's states that the purpose of her lesson is to enable her grade three students to categorize and classify four groups of animals from the story written by Lindsay Barrett George, *Around the Pond: Who's Been Here?* Two characters in the story, *Cammy* and *William*, follow an old deer path around a pond in search of blueberries. But, unexpectedly they find a lot more. Clue after clue tells them what kind of animal has been there before and left its trace behind. The story is hugely intriguing to students and they all attend closely to the oral reading of it. The clues foster many ideas, providing fodder for all to consider possible animals that may have visited the pond.

Pam's oral reading of the story provides a wonderfully rich text, provoking much individual and collective thinking. But, Pam describes how at the conclusion of the story she backs away from exploring the generative thinking students relay and, instead, quickly moves to articulating a definition of categorization to students. Initially, students seem to attempt to make sense of the concept of categorization as she articulates it: "Categorizing is when you form groups based on similar characteristics." But, the attempt is not sustained. Some students struggle with the connections to the story and are confused. Some students do not want to be sidetracked from pondering the clues to identify the animals and resist the task of categorization. Some students are able to distinguish a few of the four categories—birds, fish, mammals, and reptiles—and are enthused to seek more. After struggling for quite a few moments as to how to reorient her lesson, Pam asks one of the students how he arrived at the category of fish. She then asks everyone to trace this boy's thinking just as the story suggests. By walking through the clues together, Pam reengages students while constructing a map on the whiteboard of how fish became identified as a category.

The collective building of this visible map enables Pam to foster learning connections. She moves students into small groups and has them address some related tasks. These tasks are sequential and students move through accordingly—naming the animals in the book, placing each animal in a category, suggesting additional ways to categorize the identified animals, and listing other things that we categorize in our communities. Groups work well together and move through the tasks at varied paces. Pam enjoys visiting with each group and enabling their efforts. The lesson concludes with the recess bell and some students are reluctant to put their tasks aside to go outside for recess.

As Pam and I talk following the conduct of her lesson, she tells me how nervous she was that students "would not get the concept of categorization." She goes on to tell me that she felt very aware of the funny looks students were giving her as she finished reading the story aloud and as she stated what categorization meant. Pam describes the ensuing panic and the floundering for control of the lesson. She tells me she is very thankful that one student provided a way for her to move the lesson productively forward. And, she also tells me that this is when she slowed down and deliberately tried to attend more closely to what students were making sense of within the story. Pam states, "Slowing down helped me see more and I got more comfortable with this as I saw it working."

Together we unpack what Pam was seeing and hearing and how she uses this information to adapt her lesson to fit the given understandings. Pam begins to explore how the content of her lesson on categorization brings varied students' understandings into play and how her lesson needs to create room for all to grow these understandings. Pam's tentative explorations allow her to seek a teaching rhythm, responsive to these varied understandings. Through continued conversation we agree that the multiple paces and directions emerging entail much further deliberations and negotiations on Pam's part. We conclude with talking about such seeing and acting as a mindful teaching mode, insist-

ing on attention to curricular making's embracing of the given within all situations as the necessary starting place for learning.

Pam's willingness to mindfully enter and dwell within the relationships present and already at play in her lesson is the invitation extended through the generative process of curriculum making. Knowledge as the continual seeking of learning connections, enlarging and deepening every student's efforts, and the continuing nature of these efforts, orients Pam towards learning as growth and the recursive nature of planning for teaching to invite, nurture, and sustain the given texture of understandings within all curricular situations. (Field Notes, 10/22/12)

3. "The ability to be conscious of remaining in between past and future, neither ceasing to listen to the past nor becoming closed to the future" (Davey, 2006, p. 60).

Davey draws attention to structuring space/time to bring the present's potential to immediate attention. Lindsay grapples with seeing and acting within the present in her grade four math classroom and begins to restructure her lesson in response.

From the onset, Lindsay's lesson holds much student interest. She begins with the question: "If the class was going to order one pizza what do you suppose is a fair way to figure out what kind of pizza to order?" Students make many suggestions including voting, surveying, and arbitrarily selecting a type from a collection. Lindsay is focusing on moving the responses towards students' understandings of terms such as data, tally charts, and deductive reasoning. But, students' responses to her opening question confront the nature of fairness. Several heated discussions start to form as allergies, cultural practices, religious beliefs, and inclusivity, surface as considerations that a vote or survey would not necessarily reveal.

Lindsay comments to me that she had not anticipated the fascination with perceived fairness. And, that the unraveling of her lesson made her very nervous. But, at the same time, she also comments that she knew that the students' thinking was important and that she needed to attend to this movement. Lindsay convinces her students to walk through a less controversial topic (promising that they will return to the pizza discussion later) to examine a simple survey and collect data concerning favorite colors. Using the color wheel in the classroom with primary and secondary colors, she involves students in voting for their favorite color and recording this information on the whiteboard on a tally chart. Students get firsthand practice with reading and interpreting the tally chart that emerges. One student comments that if we are going to paint the classroom purple he is going to be sick. Others chime in, and Lindsay returns students to considering what information the tally chart reveals as she begins to address the limits of tally charts as students are noting.

Next, Lindsay has students collect their own data and create their own tally charts in small groupings concerning a survey of preferred ways to travel. As groups organize the particulars of their survey, each group is assigned to one of the K-3 classrooms to collect the data. Lindsay is very involved with all

groups as the surveys take shape. And, students love the task. As the surveys are collected and the tally charts compiled, the varying survey formats and results are shared and discussed as a whole. Most of the surveys noted cars, planes, boats, and trains, but some additionally noted bikes, skateboards, skis, horses, walking, and scooters. And, one survey allowed for other forms of travel not noted on the survey. So, the results varied widely across the various surveys despite the common topic. Lindsay tells me the breadth of these responses was totally unexpected, as she had planned her lesson. But, she goes on to tell me how she also knew that to disregard these responses felt wrong. The issues raised by students complicate Lindsay's lesson plan but she understands that it is being productively complicated and yet students are acquiring the terms referenced at the beginning of her lesson.

Students keep reminding Lindsay about the pizza survey and so eventually the final task of the lesson becomes a survey of the class regarding favorite pizza toppings. And, collectively they decide that using the tally chart created they could actually make a pizza that allowed for everyone's preferences "to be totally fair."

In conversation following the lesson, I affirm Lindsay's boldness to genuinely enter into meaning making with her students. The cooperating teacher joins in and suggests that students' concerns for fairness may have come from a recent workshop all students participated in on bullying. The three of us talk about the past, present, future connections that the lesson elicited and that Lindsay might follow up on. We are all reminded of how the thinking that evolves is not simply the workings of the teacher's, but rather, demands a mindful teaching mode that is purposefully inclusive of others. We retrace how students entered into meaning making, remaking meaning again and again through seeing other(s), hearing other(s), analyzing other(s), connecting other(s), and selecting with and through other(s). Lindsay concretely experiences how the present deserves to be fully explored and how these explorations hold much learning potential. (Field Notes, 10/03/12)

4. "The ability to approach the future as a space in which the unfulfilled potentials of past understanding can be realized" (Davey, 2006, p. 60).

Davey draws attention to meaning making's interdependence with translating room. Cassandra is immersed in a grade five classroom and a social studies lesson brings the translating room and the associated roles of imagination and embodied understandings within learning into greater focus for her.

Cassandra distributed folders to her grade five students labeled very noticeably, "TOP SECRET." The lesson is designed to be a review at the end of a unit of study concerning early people in North America by region. She explains that they are all involved in a top-secret mission. In assigned groupings, students are instructed to discreetly open their top-secret files disclosing their new identity as an early people of North America. Each group is then given time to generate clues that will be offered to the rest of the class toward determining identification. Their associated textbooks, Internet sites, and

learning artifacts used throughout the unit of study, become the resources for each group.

As the Inuit group shares their clues with the remaining members of the class, debate breaks out concerning settlement patterns and social organizations with other groups identifying with some of the Inuit clues. Cassandra finds herself unable to facilitate the heated debate and so shuts it down by insisting that all students return to reviewing the material on their own to study for the unit test. Students all groan but gradually follow through. Cassandra monitors her students by walking around ensuring compliance.

Cassandra is visibly shaken as she speaks with me following her lesson. I stress with her that the lesson was initially really well received by students and ask her why she became so disappointed. Her response relays that the lesson did not accomplish the reviewing process she envisioned in preparation for the test. It is a test that Cassandra has designed herself. As we look at the test together, we talk about the kinds of answers she is seeking and why. As we reflect on matters at the heart of the heated debate, Cassandra begins to see that students were really engaged in learning as they initially worked in their groups developing an early peoples' identity. And, she begins to think about the ensuing cross-group debates as the work of learning too. I explain to her that I saw students meaning making—drawing on their experiences, negotiating connections, and starting to envision thinking not necessarily seen coming in advance by students or Cassandra. This is a realization for her that comes as a surprise, but then she catches herself stating, "It is usually me in classes raising another interpretation, particularly concerning so-called historical facts. Somehow I guess I forgot this with my own students." We pursue ways she might have enabled students to further the debate in productive ways. We recall the specifics of what students were drawing attention to and begin to think about the varied resources and the subjective nature of interpretation. A continuing conversation is initiated about what constitutes knowledge and what genuine learning looks and feels like, alongside deliberately confronting her teaching identity.

We agree that she should return to the debate with students and acknowledge that it was indeed worthwhile as long as they debate the issues, trying to remain open to learning with and through others, and not get unruly with each other. Both the cooperating teacher and myself agree to assist her with the needed context inviting translating room for her students to further debate, challenge each other's thinking, explore and speculate, gaining enlarged realizations. Cassandra also decides to develop another test; one that also allows for students to articulate their stances more fully.

The conversation with Cassandra opens into the needed teacher mindfulness that makes physical and imaginary room for students to share their understandings alongside willingness for all to change and transform their thinking. The needed space to support the ensuing questions, discomfort, and deliberations in order to grow new thinking, takes a mindful teaching mode that understands the future is always being reconstructed by and for all involved, drawing on past understandings. (Field Notes, 11/14/12)

ROOM FOR PROSPECTIVE TEACHERS TO SEEK THE TEMPORALITY AT PLAY WITHIN THE PRESENT

The representative accounts of prospective teachers' attempts at mindful curricular engagement bring the present's potential to immediate attention. Dewey (1938) explains, "We have to understand the significance of what we see, hear, and touch. This significance consists of the consequences that will result when what is seen is acted upon" (p. 68). It is such significance gained through mindful negotiation of the present from within prospective teachers' curricular enactment that must be practiced. Davey (2006) relays how the features of the past-present-future movement he articulates need a "practiced receptiveness" (p. 66). And, it is a practiced receptiveness that the prospective teachers' accounts reveal, gradually orienting the direction of thinking away from being imposed, to agency coming from within the moving experience of engaged students and teachers adapting, changing, and building meaning together.

When what is seen is acted upon, the mindful terrain of curricular engagement unfolds through ongoing discernment and deliberation, cultivating confidence in process and a lived language of practice to articulate to others. Thus, the representative accounts from prospective teachers reveal how mindful curricular engagement is not scripted, nor formulaic, but rather, take multiple forms, interdependent with the particulars of situation. The catalytic role of educators committed to this pedagogical mode is emphasized, alongside giving expression to the impacts for learners and learning invested in growing strong student identities valuing interactions, deliberations, and debates. It is the unfolding relational challenges, tensions, and diverse ideas and gifts, within the complex social and emotional terrain of curricular engagement that hold the significances for learning and learners. Mindful curricular engagement characterizes the varied ways the play of challenges, tensions, and diverse ideas and gifts, reframes and reorients the ensuing thinking movement, critically providing the much-needed sustenance for genuine learning within educative settings of all kinds.

Room for prospective teachers to practice the receptivity of curricular engagement, enables them to deliberate and discern the formative terrain encountered and not simply cover pre-formulated content. Rather, relationships among students, teacher, and subject matter become the materials of curriculum. Recognizing these raw materials as being present within the experiences of students, teacher, and the subject matter itself and finding ways to build relationships connecting students, teacher, and subject matter, characterizes mindful curricular engagement. As these relationships emerge and develop, the prospective teachers' capacities to orient curricular engagement to further learning is derived from an intimate understanding of students and situation. Deliberation of these relationships is the indispensable

condition of mindful curricular engagement—coming into being as a manifesting, evoking, and transforming movement. Curriculum is not applied or imposed, but a mindful knowing in action, seeing and acting within curricular enactment demanding attentiveness to the present, understanding that the past is alive in the present, holding implications for the future. Such mindful modes of being need to be practiced—acquiring the sensitivities, capacities, habits, and ways of working, to enhance confidence and a language of practice to articulate to others what mindful curricular engagement orients learning toward and why. Students and others will cultivate these same mindful modes of being, then, too.

CONCLUDING THOUGHTS

The notion of mindfulness draws across varied East, West, and indigenous traditions and perspectives (see for example: Ie, Ngnoumen, & Langer, 2014; Four Arrows, Cajete, & Lee, 2010). Much of the contemporary research literature documents how mindful practices such as meditations, awareness of the breath, noticing thoughts, attending to sounds, and feeling emotional responses, enable focus, heighten empathy, dissipate stress, and foster resilience (see for example: Carson, & Langer, 2006; Hanh, 1999; Masicampo & Baumeister, 2007; Nyklicek & Kuipers, 2008; Robins, Keng, Ekblad, & Brantley, 2012; Shapiro, Brown, & Biegel, 2007). There is no doubt that mindfulness offers healing to many in therapeutic situations and opens into ways we can all live well in the world with others (Kabat-Zinn, 2005). In education settings, mindful practices are documented as setting a pedagogical tone promoting greater teacher and student focus, comfort and ease in situations, and coping strategies to manage and operate efficiently (see for example: Bernay, 2014; Poulin, Mackenzie, Soloway, & Karayolas, 2008; Schonert-Reichl & Stewart Lawlor, 2010). But, in education settings, I believe (along with others) we are shortchanging mindfulness's powers and possibilities if it is not also embraced as an ongoing relational negotiation (see for example: Hocking, Haskell, & Linds, 2001; Orr, 2002, 2014; Park, 2007; Ritchart & Perkins, 2000). Not only can mindfulness set and enhance pedagogical tone, but mindfulness as a relational negotiation holds potential to wholly embody what it means to teach and to learn/live. This study reveals how mindful curricular engagement entails receptive seeing/acting within its enactment through adapting, changing, building, and making meaning, both individually and collectively. Heightened attention to the responsible/responsive movement of thinking at the heart of making meaning for all involved occurs, cultivating greater educator/student awareness accompanied by discernment. Prospective teachers' practiced receptiveness within curricular engagement suggests powers and possibilities for learning through mindfully

attending to the temporality at play with their present curricular situations. These powers and possibilities are glimpsed through opportunities for prospective teachers to attend to the elemental connectedness of meaning making with the nature of being human, meaning making's embracing of the given within all situations, meaning making's need of others, and meaning making's interdependence with imagination, instilling embodied understandings. Folding into one another, these opportunities prompt the much-needed practice for educators to see and act inciting mindful curricular engagement. But, prospective educators in this study just barely began to see and act with discernment and deliberation and much more practice is needed to cultivate these powers and possibilities further. Collectively, we all glimpsed the tremendous potential mindfulness as a relational practice holds for reorganizing school structures and reframing what education ought to entail. Teacher education programs must instill the needed conditions for prospective teachers to see and act accordingly to incite the powers and possibilities to do so.

NOTE

1. Data shared in this account is from a study 2010–12 designed to encourage prospective teachers to foster teaching identities concerned with seeing and building pedagogical relationships. Two elementary school sites in a small city in the midwest of the United States with sixteen cooperating teachers and twenty prospective educators volunteer to participate. Prospective educators attend a weekly seminar (focus group) concerning relational pedagogy alongside working closely with a cooperating teacher in their classroom over a four-month period. The researcher conducts the seminar and documents the journeys of each prospective educator. Data sources include: 1) narratives of theory/practice experiences written and shared regularly by prospective educators with each other, cooperating teachers, and the researcher; 2) lesson planning artifacts from prospective educators; 3) audiotaped conversations on an individual and focus group basis documenting efforts to negotiate pedagogical relationships; and, 4) researcher field notes/observations of prospective educators' teaching efforts, with these notes/observations serving as a springboard for continued explorations invested in developing teaching identities practicing relational pedagogy, across all data sources. Each prospective educator is understood as a distinct case, demanding researcher responsive to the given particularities. A cross-case analysis then follows, identifying common themes to all cases as well as significant differences among cases. Anonymity is assured with all data coded and pseudonyms incorporated for all identifying information.

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